A SPACE-FANTASY ROLEPLAYING GAME

# LANTERN REACH

## Guide's Book

Encounters, adventures and the opening arc



**CORE / ALPHA 0.3.1 / PLAYTEST EDITION**

An original space-fantasy adventure RPG.
Pantheons. Strange worlds. A crew of your own.

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# Using this book

This is an original space-fantasy roleplaying game for two to four players and one Guide. A duet option supports one player and one Guide. Use two ordinary six-sided dice, paper and tokens; miniatures and the offline companion are optional.

GUIDE MATERIAL CONTAINS SPOILERS. Read the Player's Book core resolution and ship rules before running the adventures. The Silent Berth, The Glass Orchard and Quiet Glass form a complete opening space-adventure arc. The Unclaimed Crossing is an optional groundside side adventure.

The default campaign follows a crew with a ship: travel, strange worlds, civilizations, dangerous encounters, artifacts and personal quests. Pantheons matter to identity, powers and daily life. Zeal is restrained and contextual; territorial management is an optional campaign module.

Species, bodily nature, upbringing, profession, specialization and religion are separate choices. Humans include many factions, beliefs and ways of existing. Nothing requires one species or body to follow a particular Pantheon.

The numbered rule chapters preserve the manuscript numbering across both books. Chapters 04 and 11 belong to the Guide's Book; the other numbered chapters belong to the Player's Book. Setting and play-aid sections are separately labeled. Blue internal references link to a chapter when it is in this volume.

Manifest Destiny / Rise of the Zealots provide inspiration, not a requirement to reproduce their source world. Original Lantern Reach figures, peoples and places develop independently; source-game characters are not silently rewritten.

This alpha has editorial checks, mathematical analysis and tested software aids. It has not completed external live tabletop playtests and does not claim proven balance or the breadth of established commercial games. The repository contains the editable source, development notes and playtest record.

## Readiness and ownership

Players own their characters' beliefs and choices. Agree on tone before play and pause when needed. No rule forces religious conviction, personal disclosure or one predetermined solution to a scene. A Guide gives concrete opportunities and consequences, then lets the crew choose its route.

# Start / Guide preparation

## Read in this order

1. Read the player start and core chapter 1, particularly task clocks, attack/defense, damage order, Downed and refresh timing.
2. Read The Silent Berth once. Mark its actual situation, four NPC needs, Rescue OR Power reward condition and Reserve timing.
3. Keep the ship reference, ready characters and station map available. Read the full ship chapter only if pursuit/boarding becomes relevant.
4. Give players ready sheets or the offline aid. Ask each for a reason to travel and one connection to the crew. Don't begin with an encyclopedia quiz.

## Prepare six things

- Two leads: station rescue and planetary survey. Have the alternate adventure available if you offer it. If time only permits one, be honest at the table about the prepared scenario and let players choose its approach.
- The ship/crew pools and four initial station clocks, with the explanation that Rescue OR Power satisfies the paid mission.
- What NPCs offer freely: dock code, visible occupancy facts, technical fault on inspection, ordinary conversation.
- A specific consequence for likely risks, such as +1 Reserve on a failed repair; no extra hidden enemy attacks.
- The opening opposition count: one Rifle Guard for two PCs, two for four, and only if the fight actually happens. People can cooperate.
- One future lead for a PC's personal quest so the session points beyond its immediate job.

## Opening ten minutes

Establish tone and an easy pause signal. Describe Meridian's working port and the rescue call. Ask what each PC is doing when it arrives. Show the known job terms and ship departure cost. Answer sensible practical questions without a roll. Once the crew chooses, narrate the safe leg and move directly to the station.

Give the first meaningful character choice early: hail the skiff, scan the station, offer a bargain or dock. Let abilities reveal something useful, then make the resulting opportunity concrete. “You learn the reactor fault” should lead to a reachable panel and a choice, not another unexplained hidden lock.

## Pacing targets, not a script

For a 2-3-hour meeting, allow roughly 15 minutes for setup/launch, 30 for arrival/social investigation, 45 for rescue/repair, 20 for any conflict and 15 for aftermath/next leads. The unused time belongs to player decisions and breaks. If a productive scene takes longer, compress routine movement and repeat exposition before adding more obstacles.

The mission can end peacefully. If the table wants tactical play, make a real disagreement/goal visible; don't attack people who have accepted a credible settlement just to use a stat block. Quill's pursuit is optional, not a mandatory second fight after a mandatory first fight.

# If play stalls

| Situation | Useful response |
|---|---|
| Nobody knows where to go | Repeat two visible leads and what each might achieve |
| A required clue was missed | Move that factual clue to a reachable observation or informed person |
| One roll failed | Apply the stated consequence and show what changed; give another approach |
| Everyone repeats the same roll | Ask for changed tools/method or resolve the now-unopposed task without dice |
| A player can't find a useful ability | Offer an ordinary move, Help, objective action or informed question; avoid choosing their beliefs/plan for them |
| Reserve fills | Use the written backup-air/evacuation consequence and reachable exit |
| All PCs are Downed | Use the named rescue/capture/debt consequence and preserve the campaign's next choice |
| Players want a theological answer | Give the actual observable phenomenon and an NPC interpretation; the crew can investigate further |

# After play

Pay the promised reward, permit immediate purchases before Supply cap, award only earned milestones and record changed Trust/contacts. Ask what the crew wants to pursue next. Collect playtest observations, distinguishing facts from suggested fixes. A rule question, a confusing name or a boring turn is useful evidence; a completed session isn't automatically a passed balance test.

# Keep the whole crew in the scene

Before asking the same specialist for another task roll, ask what everyone else is doing. Offer parallel work: moving a resident, opening the memory-case door, arranging Quill's settlement, obtaining Rask's signature, preparing a safe route, or tending a frightened passenger. Ordinary useful actions stay automatic; do not invent a roll to justify participation. A helper may use core Help for an edge, respecting the modifier cap. Players may pass or let the specialist lead. This is an invitation, not a required rotation or extra success tax.

Bring parallel actions together before applying the announced Reserve trigger. Never charge a full investigation scene per individual PC, nor another scene merely for changing rooms. If the crew has secured the residents and declined repair, pay the bond and move to the outcome; filling optional Power is not required to finish the adventure.

# 04 / Guide toolkit

## Run a scene

Describe a place, a person who needs something, and pressure that makes delay matter. Ask what the protagonists do. Reveal what they can perceive without charging a roll. Before a risky action announce what success achieves and what failure or partial success costs. Choose consequences that change the situation, not merely delay it. On a miss introduce a new fact, loss, separation, exposure or advancing danger. Do not conceal essential information behind one mandatory roll.

Present problems with at least three plausible approaches: force, negotiation and changing conditions. Let unexpected approaches work. A door is not immune to tools because you prepared a conversation. An opponent is not immune to conversation because you prepared a fight.

### Scene stakes

| Pressure | Partial cost example | Failure consequence example |
|---|---|---|
| Climbing a dangerous route | 1 Strain or lose equipment | Land in lower zone, 1 damage |
| Bargaining under suspicion | A public promise or 1 Supply | Offer refused; rival learns your purpose |
| Repairing unstable machinery | 1 Supply or reduced progress | Alarm, leak or new dangerous access route |
| Channeling a rite under scrutiny | 1 Strain | No effect and 1 Strain, using rite rules |
| Working a rescue clock | 1 progress without cost, or 2 with a stated cost when explicitly offered | Hazard advances; survivors remain reachable |

Avoid inventing extra Strain costs on top of a rite's stated partial/failure costs. A combat action uses its own consequences, not an unrelated free enemy attack.

## Encounters

For rank 1 start with **one regular enemy per two PCs, rounded up**. More enemy turns are often more dangerous than higher Guard. Two regular enemies plus one leader is a severe encounter for four PCs and should allow avoidance or retreat. A leader replaces two regulars; a frail enemy counts as half a regular. At ranks 3-5 add one regular to an ordinary encounter only after observing the group's results. These are hypotheses, not measured encounter balance.

Enemies flee, surrender or bargain when their objective is lost, their leader falls, or half their group is Downed. A character can use an action to offer a credible exit; if the reason to fight is gone, accept without rolling. Do not fight to the last hit point by default.

All profiles have one move and one action. Guard 0 removes ordinary NPCs from combat; decide surrender, flight or incapacitation from the fiction. Armor is continuous damage reduction; only listed units have it. No profile gets a PC's limited light-armor item unless explicitly added.

| Adversary | Guard | Armor | Damage/range | Action or behavior |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Frightened Watcher (frail) | 2 | 0 | 1/ranged | Warns before firing; flees when approached by two foes |

| Adversary | Guard | Armor | Damage/range | Action or behavior |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Gate Defender (regular) | 4 | 1 | 2/close | Can spend action taking cover instead of attacking |
| Pursuer (regular) | 4 | 0 | 2/close | Can sprint instead of attacking; seeks the carrier |
| Rifle Guard (regular) | 3 | 0 | 2/ranged | Uses terrain; offers surrender when isolated |
| Zeal Channeler (regular) | 3 | 0 | 1/ranged | Instead of attack, grants one ally 1 damage reduction against next hit before channeler's next turn |
| Engine Tender (regular) | 4 | 0 | 1/close | Instead of attack restores 1 Guard to an adjacent-in-fiction device or retinue; cannot revive a Downed unit |
| Relic Sentinel (leader) | 7 | 1 | 3/close | Telegraphs one adjacent zone; next turn may move there and attack one target. No extra turn |
| Creed Marshal (leader) | 6 | 1 | 2/ranged | Instead of attack, one ally may immediately move one zone, not attack |
| Unbound Echo (leader) | 6 | 0 | 2/close | Instead of attack, everyone in its zone defends against 1 Strain; on 7-9 take it or move to an adjacent zone, 10+ avoid, 6- take it |

These are generic tabletop profiles, not established species, gods or faction rosters. An Echo is an optional supernatural phenomenon. No starter scene requires it to exist.

## Spacefaring threats

Use these alongside humanoid adversaries. Alien wildlife is not a species' moral alignment, and independent machines can be characters rather than disposable equipment. A drone below is a non-sentient device; hacking a sentient person uses different rules.

| Adversary | Guard | Armor | Damage/range | Behavior / counterplay |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Survey Drone (frail) | 2 | 0 | 1/ranged | Records and retreats; ordinary terminal access can turn off its alarm |
| Repair Automaton (regular) | 4 | 1 | 1/close | Defends a work zone; recognizes a valid maintenance order without a combat roll |

| Adversary | Guard | Armor | Damage/range | Behavior / counterplay |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Terrace Grazer (regular) | 5 | 0 | 2/close | Territorial; leaves people alone beyond its nesting zone; can be distracted by food/noise |
| Stalker Fauna (regular) | 3 | 0 | 2/close | Hides in one stated terrain type; scanner or Echo Sense can reveal presence within its range |
| Boarding Specialist (regular) | 4 | 0 | 2/close | Instead of attacking, can seal one ordinary hatch; tools/action reopen it when uncontested |
| Heavy Security Frame (leader) | 8 | 1 | 3/ranged | Must spend an action visibly bracing before firing; moving cancels brace, ordinary access credentials can stand it down |

Heavy Security Frame replaces two regulars. Do not introduce several ship-scale cannons as personal enemies. Core player attack/defense rolls remain the same regardless of the fiction's technology.

## A short campaign

Start with the Lantern Reach, a crew ship, two reachable jobs and one personal question per PC. Give each location a physical discovery, cultural discovery and unanswered mystery. Give each faction a useful service, an internal disagreement and an actual reason to negotiate. Human factions include different bodies, beliefs and professions; do not present engineered, mechanical, psionic or devout humans as single civilizations.

Rotate objectives: rescue, survey, recover, escort, investigate, negotiate, survive. A fight should have a purpose besides eliminating every enemy. A religious mission may explore a festival, a vanished pilgrim, disputed ownership or sacred history without conversion. A secular job can develop a character's faith through choices rather than a Zeal reward.

Use Prophets as people with far-reaching commitments, rather than final bosses whose statistics explain their divinity. Do not invent a canonical Prophet's position on a new event without source support. Begin with local agents and develop shared canon deliberately. If the group explicitly chooses a territorial campaign, prepare three sites and two rival projects using chapter 3's optional module; otherwise omit it.

## Rewards

Award milestones by the advancement rules. Offer material rewards of 1-4 Supply or a useful connection; information and safe access are often more valuable than another weapon. Relics grant one narrow new option with an explicit cost. Do not issue permanent flat bonuses that evade the modifier cap. A prototype relic: **Listening Shard**-once per session ask which of two named nearby communities is under greater immediate pressure; to activate, spend 1 Conviction and publicly name one obligation you will undertake. This reveals pressure, not private thoughts or supernatural truth.

## Explain unresolved rulings

If no rule covers an action, identify the nearest existing action and announce intent/risk/effect. Make a temporary ruling, record it, and keep play moving. Don't silently invent exceptions to save a villain or force an ending. Rules changes happen between scenes with the table's understanding.

# 11 / Threats and encounter design

A combat scene needs a reason to move, a reason to choose something other than maximum damage, and a believable way to end. The numerical model in analysis/README.md covers only a narrow stationary baseline. It suggests the starter count of one regular per two PCs is a low-risk teaching conflict, not a measured universal difficulty rating. Rites, terrain, objectives, group decisions and special actions change the actual challenge.

## Build the scene before the enemy list

Write five short answers:

1. **What must the crew achieve?** Rescue someone, reach a control, keep a route open, hold off pursuit, recover an object, disable a weapon, survive or defeat a foe.
2. **What do opponents want?** Name an objective, a target or an escape condition. They don't all optimize for killing the weakest PC.
3. **Where can the plan change?** At least two traversable routes and one useful terrain feature. A locked passage needs a visible alternate or a stated way to open it.
4. **What pressure is visible?** Announced countdown, moving cargo, failing cover, incoming reinforcement or an environmental event. Do not advance every possible clock for the same elapsed time.
5. **What ends the conflict?** Objective secured, opposition retreats, agreement, capture, withdrawal or an announced last-stand condition. A foe who will not retreat needs a specific reason, not secret immunity to morale.

For a new group start small and use the teaching counts. For an experienced group, increase the tactical problem first. An elite or two-part threat may replace multiple regulars rather than simply join them. Track Downed characters, resource use and time at actual tables before publishing difficulty bands. Don't use the model's win fractions as a promise.

## Terrain that matters

| Feature | Rule |
|---|---|
| **Solid cover** | Spend an action taking cover at a stated position. PC gets ranged defense edge; shooting a covered NPC gives hindrance. Moving/attacking ends it. It is not a permanent bonus for everyone merely sharing a zone |
| **Opaque partition** | Blocks visibility and ranged attacks across it. A door, vent or route can bypass it; scans may reveal presence without granting a shot |
| **High gantry** | Scenario can grant a clear two-connection ranged position. Reaching it takes a route/action or task, and lower opaque walls still block sight |
| **Low gravity** | Prepared suits/anchors allow normal moves; an unsecured character needs a surface/pack to change direction. No automatic universal Finesse penalty |
| **Hazard lane** | Mark a zone and warning; entering or remaining at the stated moment triggers one specified defense/effect. Friendly and enemy targets follow the same physical hazard unless their profile explicitly adapts |
| **Control station** | Working it uses an action or task clock. Describe what operating it changes; it isn't automatically a victory button and needn't demand one Vocation |

Once an announced blast has resolved, don't quietly reset it every round unless a repeat cycle was established. Destroyed cover stays destroyed. A partially completed objective keeps progress unless a specific action reverses it; enemies don't erase it by existing nearby.

## Specialized opponents

These original profiles can represent several peoples or affiliations. Human gene-craft, machinery, psionic practice and religion are not automatic allegiances or villain flags. Every unit uses one move/action per activation and normal PC defense rolls. Any reaction below consumes its one reaction for that round.

| Threat | Guard / armor | Attack | Distinct action / counterplay |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Biotic Vanguard** - regular | 5 / 0 | 2, close | Instead of attack restores 2 of its own Guard if conscious. No resurrection. Pressure it away from its objective or separate it from a repair window |
| **Psionic Disruptor** - regular | 3 / 0 | 1, ranged | Instead of attack target one conscious foe in own/adjacent visible zone: Presence or Insight defense; 6- lose 1 Conviction (or gain 1 Strain if at 0), 7-9 choose that loss or move one adjacent safe zone, 10+ resist. No belief/behavior control |
| **Signal Hunter** - regular | 4 / 0 | 2, ranged | Instead of attack scan one adjacent zone: reveal active transmitters or drones until next turn. Opaque shielding blocks it; simply switching off an ordinary communicator works |

| Threat | Guard / armor | Attack | Distinct action / counterplay |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Boarding Breacher** - regular | 4 / 1 | 2, close | Instead of attack open one ordinary sealed hatch or place a one-use charge. Announces the charge zone; it deals 2 defended damage there at end of next round and can be removed with an action before then |
| **Gravitic Stalker** - elite | 6 / 0 | 3, close | Once/round reaction after taking damage, move one adjacent zone along an unblocked route. No extra attack. Anchored barriers or closing a hatch can stop it |
| **Astral Duelist** - elite | 6 / 0 | 2, close | Instead of attack, name a visible target and guard a route until next turn. If that target crosses it, their move stops in duelist's zone unless they spend an action to evade/contest with a Finesse task roll; no free damage |
| **Deflector Frame** - elite | 7 / 1 | 2, ranged | Once/round reaction reduce one incoming hit by 1 after armor, minimum 0. A successful ordinary terminal shutdown task or observed energy interruption can suppress the reaction for one round |
| **Voidmaw** - elite fauna | 7 / 0 | 3, close | On a hit that actually deals Guard damage, can pull the target with it into an adjacent safe zone if the route fits both. Announce the intent; Anchor Frame or an ally's physical tether can prevent movement, not damage |

An elite is usually a replacement for two regulars, not evidence that its statistics are calibrated for every rank. A heavily armored solitary foe may take a long time but produce few meaningful decisions; give it movement, an objective or a visible weakness instead of more armor.

## Two-part threats

Large creatures and machines can have **two visible components**, each with its own Guard and activation, instead of one secret boss getting extra turns. Announce both components and their role before round 1. Each counts as a unit for alternating activation. Destroying/disabling one removes its activation. No surprise replacement phase unless its approach was visibly telegraphed. Whole-body effects such as a pin can't immobilize a ship-sized object through a human-scale ability, but can still target reachable human-scale components where plausible.

### Sun-Eater Engine · encounter example

An abandoned energy-harvesting rig is drawing a habitat's power into an unstable corona. It is a malfunctioning installation, not a moral faction or confirmed deity. Zones: Approach, Relay Walk, Crown Platform, Shielded Console and Escape Dock. Approach connects to Walk/Console; Walk connects to Crown; Console connects to Crown/Dock; Dock connects to Approach. Opaque shielding separates Console from Approach until its hatch opens.

**Collector Crown:** Guard 5, armor 0. Action marks one adjacent zone with a bright warning; at its next activation it may discharge into that zone for 2 defended damage to everyone present, then loses the mark. Mark and discharge are separate activations. Disabling Crown stops discharges already marked.

**Tether Spindle:** Guard 6, armor 1. Action attacks one visible character in own/adjacent zone for 2 damage; on an actually damaging hit they are pinned to an available surface until next turn unless they spend an action cutting free. It cannot seal every exit or pin an entire party.

**Alternatives:** physical breaks at the exposed cables fill a 4-clock task (Force/Finesse) to disable Spindle; a 6-clock technical shutdown at Console (Insight or useful ritual-assisted work) disables both. Each task failure advances an announced Feedback countdown 1; partial gives 1 progress or 2 +1 Strain. Full success gives 2 progress and exceptional success 3 as normal. Feedback starts 0/6 and advances once at the end of each round while Crown is active. At 6, the rig ejects its power cell: everyone gets a warning and one final move toward Dock; the rig is lost, the habitat survives on backup, and evacuation becomes the objective. There is no unannounced unavoidable party death.

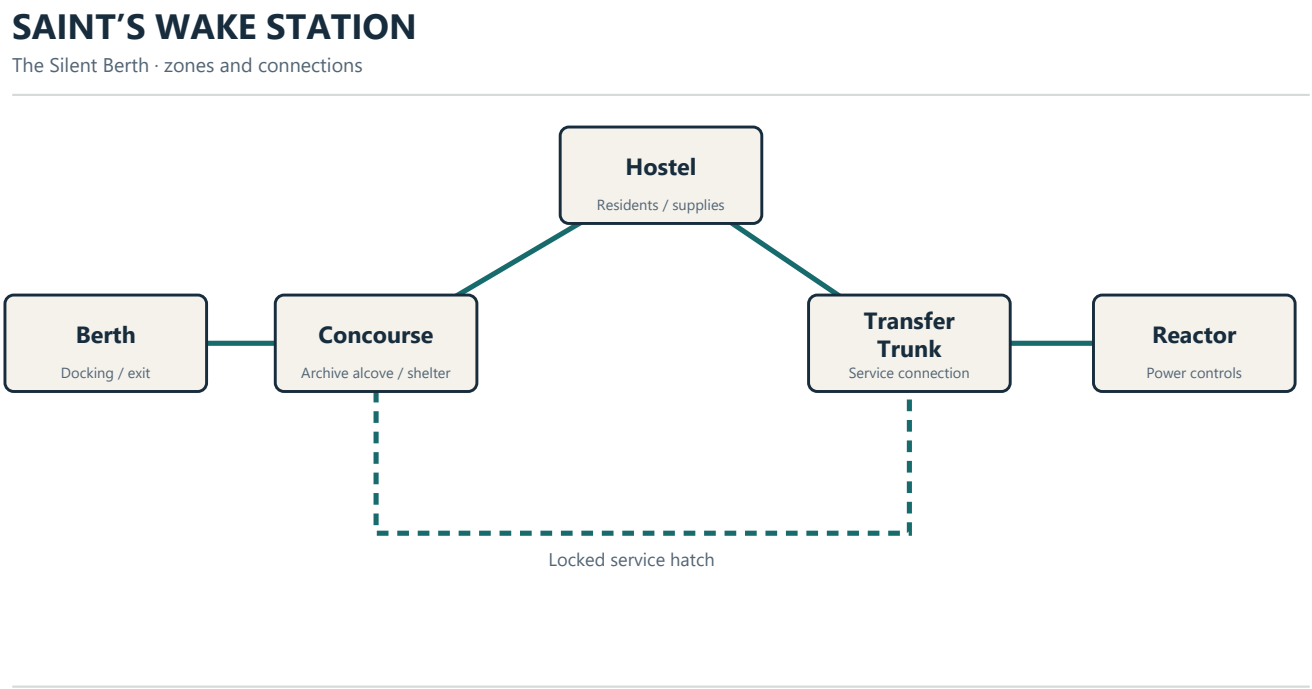
For two PCs use one component at a time: Crown begins active and Spindle inactive. After Crown is disabled, announce Spindle waking and give the crew one full round before its first activation. Alternatively, a clearly warned power surge can switch Crown off and Spindle on; never leave both active together in a teaching game. Disabled Crown stops Feedback's automatic end-round advance as stated above. For a higher-rank four-PC group, add one moving objective (rescue an engineer stranded at Walk) before raising numbers. Test the scene; don't label it balanced from its stat block alone.

## Reinforcements and retreat

If reinforcements matter, state their source, entry, timing and interruption condition: “two breachers arrive at Dock at end of round 3 unless the alarm relay is disabled.” An enemy's action triggering the alarm is a real action, not free extra pressure appended to every miss. Keep the total number of active units manageable. Waves are not an excuse to cancel a clever plan.

Retreat uses the map. When the crew reaches a safe exit with no pursuer able or willing to contest it, leave rounds. A blocked chase can become one movement/social task with a stated cost; do not require five identical flee rolls. A villain may escape with an objective, making the crew lose the mission without losing its characters. That is a useful consequence, not a failure of combat design.

# Adventure I / The Silent Berth




**Guide only · rank 1 · 2-4 PCs + Guide · 2-3 hours**

The crew is at Meridian Anchorage with its starting ship and Stores 4. Saint's Wake Station has stopped answering normal traffic. A fragmented rescue call offers a berth bond worth **4 Supply** for getting its stranded residents to safety or restoring life support. A separate salvage crew holds a legal claim on abandoned machinery. The station is occupied, but the public register hasn't received its renewal.

This is an adventure about exploration, rescue, evidence, ship operations and a disputed salvage contract. Religious spaces are part of a lived-in station; nobody must convert anyone to win. All characters, places, laws and artifacts below are proposed tabletop content.

## Prepare and opening choice

Read chapters 1, 5 and 6 and the ready characters. Offer this job and one alternative before departure: survey work at Kestrel's Garden. If players choose the alternative, run The Glass Orchard; don't punish them for declining the station. If they accept the rescue, travel is one safe leg: spend 1 Stores, no navigation roll. Arrival is at Stores 3 with no automatic Hull loss.

Read/paraphrase: "The station rotates against the starfield, its public lights dark. An emergency lamp flashes above a sealed berth. Your communicator repeats six words: 'Residents present. Registry wrong. Please acknowledge.' A salvage skiff hangs beside the freight collar."

Ask who flies, who scans and who answers. Routine approach is safe. A scanner identifies breathable air in three compartments and a power discontinuity in the transfer trunk. The distress call is authentic; provide that observation without a roll. The crew can hail, dock at the normal berth, or inspect outside.

# Keyed map

Five zones: **Berth -> Concourse -> Hostel -> Transfer Trunk -> Reactor**. Also connect Concourse to Transfer Trunk through a locked service hatch. **Archive** is an alcove in Concourse, not a separate combat zone. Berth and Reactor are opaque to other zones; ranged attacks require doorway sight. The station rotates with ordinary internal gravity; outside is vacuum.

Docking to the normal berth is automatic with Rask's transmitted code, available by answering the call. An external route can reach Reactor via EVA: suit + anchored rig, then Finesse; partial +1 Strain, failure suit scrape (breach grace period from chapter 5) and remain safely tethered outside Berth. Give an alternate reachable entrance. No single failed boarding roll strands the entire crew.

Draw task clocks **Rescue 0/4**, **Power 0/6**, **Registry 0/4**. Draw countdown **Reserve 0/6**. Advance Reserve once after each major investigation scene (at most Berth, Hostel, Reactor) and at the end of each tactical round during a fight. Do not charge both scene and rounds for the same time. Successful Power completion stops it. A character at Reactor can spend an action routing reserve power, preventing that round's automatic advance; this does not cancel announced failure costs. Tell players that procedure before they decide.

At Reserve 4 the Hostel doors begin cycling; residents must move to Concourse (Rescue progress still counts). At Reserve 6 station life support stops. Give all conscious residents excursion hoods from the hostel locker, sufficient for one watch, and start an evacuation scene. Hoods prevent immediate suffocation; they do not complete unfinished Rescue work. Keep its current progress. Use the same Rescue approaches and success bands, but a failed evacuation attempt makes **1 progress and gives the acting PC 1 Strain** instead of advancing the already-full Reserve. Describe a costly completed transfer, not a passenger lost to a bad die. Previously earned Rescue progress is never erased. At completion the two short local ferry trips to the crew's ship or independent lifeboats fit inside the hood watch; local trips do not spend interstellar Stores. If everyone is Downed, Suri and Quill finish the evacuation and ask for one concrete future favor; record it without removing powers or personhood. Rescue hoods and accessible lifeboat spaces are available to all bodies. The journey back to Meridian is a second safe leg costing 1 Stores, declared before departure.

# People

| NPC | Identity / goal | What earns cooperation |
|---|---|---|
| **Lio Rask**, administrator | Mechanical human, Divinity lay observer; keep residents and records safe | Answer the distress call; he gives dock code and authority records freely |
| **Tessa Quill**, salvage captain | Augmented human, secular; recover her crew's investment and avoid false abandonment charges | Proof of occupancy plus a legitimate paid salvage opportunity; or negotiated withdrawal bond |
| **Suri Wen**, medic | Gene-crafted human, Order tradition; finish treating patients without interruption | Practical help; no religious test |
| **Vesh**, hostel steward | Veyran, Ancients Keeper; protect visitors' memories and personal property | A rescue plan respecting which belongings people can carry |

NPC identities are examples of diversity, not new biological restrictions. Rask's body is not a terminal players can hack. None speaks for an entire species or Pantheon.

# Scene 1: berth and salvage claim

Quill explains her claim, shows the outdated public register and requests access to machinery. She hasn't attacked anyone. Rask shows that residents are present. Quill agrees to **one inspection scene** before taking further action; no roll if the crew offers to check both accounts. A Presence roll can secure more time: partial promise her a fair salvage contract, failure she brings one guard to the service hatch and announces her next step. An immediate attack is avoidable.

The station's bond pays Quill **1 Supply separately** if the crew arranges legitimate removal of destroyed parts after repairs. That does not reduce the crew's 4-Supply reward and doesn't create an unlimited repeatable income. This is a concrete bargain available through questioning, not a hidden correct answer. A crew preferring blunt force can drive the skiff away, but its legal claim remains a later complication.

## Scene 2: concourse, hostel and rescue

The Concourse contains shuttered shops, a secular union noticeboard and small gathering spaces for all three Pantheons. A pot of food is still warm in the common kitchen. A shrine is not the central reactor control. Ordinary logs show a failed certificate transmission; no secret theological sabotage is necessary.

Rescue task: move four residents with mobility needs and their emergency hoods to a safe berth/refuge. Presence coordinates, Force clears a jammed trolley, Insight repairs a lift, or Finesse rigs its brake. Use task outcomes: partial 1 progress without cost or 2 progress +1 Strain; miss no progress and +1 Reserve. Completion secures the residents aboard the crew's ship or a safe Concourse air shelter for one watch. The remaining residents can follow ordinary instructions without individually rolling for each. A segment represents one resident safely positioned; larger successful actions coordinate several together. After a failure, offer a reachable changed approach: a trolley jams at a new corner, a resident needs a different support, or a brake line can be rerouted. Do not ask for an identical retry or make the player guess a password.

Rask also loans a labeled **rescue harness** from the Hostel locker. Fitting it takes ten safe minutes and advances Reserve once as a significant delay, announced before choosing. An action secures one willing or stabilized resident, and ordinary movement can carry them while the wearer gives up attacks and Sprint. It adds no Rescue progress automatically. Afterward he offers ownership for 1 Supply or a named future rescue favor; refusal changes no bond payment. Record the physical loan and return it if declined. Full fitting rules are in Signature gear.

Suri offers a medkit for practical help (one ordinary kit, not Supply). Vesh asks the crew to retrieve a passenger's memory case; it is visible behind a jammed hostel door. Force or tools open it: partial 1 Strain, miss +1 Reserve but the door opens. The case is optional and contains a damaged survey record linking Kestrel's Garden to Quiet Glass. If left, Vesh remembers the planet name and can provide the next lead anyway.

**Religious moment:** a worried visitor asks for a brief shared observance. A willing PC may give reassurance or pray; this costs no roll and creates no mechanical reward during the emergency. Waiting ten minutes to recharge powers advances Reserve once as a significant delay, declared first. Secular comfort is equally welcome.

## Scene 3: reactor and registry

The governor is intact; a coolant manifold has seized. Safe tools and bypass lines are present. Inspection gives the fault without a roll. Power 6-clock can use Insight to bypass, Force to operate stiff manual valves, or a useful rite paired with real work. Partial 1 progress or 2 by paying 1 Supply; failure +1 Reserve. Never apply both generic task failure and an extra enemy attack. Completion restores life support, recharges suits and opens a safe docking lane. A failed attempt exposes another bypass or reachable manual valve; announce that changed access before the next attempt. Tell the crew that repair unlocks Rask's one-time station service, including fuel useful to an undamaged ship.

**First ask whether Registry needs a clock.** Occupancy records, Rask's authorization and an available ship/reactor transmission link settle the update with one ordinary transmission, no roll. Rask freely authorizes a truthful record; carrying his signed statement is enough without taking him away from people who need him. Mark Registry complete. Use Registry 4 only if someone actually contests the evidence or an announced interruption makes transmission uncertain; identify that opposition first. It needs the Concourse archive and a transmission link. Insight repairs the certificate; Presence obtains witness statements; Records expertise can apply. Partial 1 progress without extra cost; failure reveals a missing signature and brings Quill to the discussion, not +1 Reserve. Rask can sign or send authorization. Once that removes the only uncertainty, transmit automatically rather than rolling to rediscover the same missing signature. Registry completion legally invalidates abandonment locally, avoiding a combat requirement.

Core required success: **Rescue OR Power** completes the paid rescue obligation; Registry determines the claim's aftermath. It is not mandatory to fill every clock before the crew can leave.

## Optional fight or ship encounter

If negotiations collapse, Quill sends **one Rifle Guard per two PCs rounded up** to secure Transfer Trunk, not shoot patients. They warn the crew and allow an exit. Use chapter 4 profiles. They accept verified occupancy evidence, a credible settlement or a protected withdrawal. Stop after one guard is Downed or their objective is clearly impossible; no fight to the death. Do not add reactor hazards as extra enemy turns.

If the crew departs with disputed property, Quill's skiff may pursue: Hull 4, damage 2, Engagement 1. Run ship rules. She demands return/inspection; surrendering disputed cargo ends pursuit. If crew has legally resolved the claim, no pursuit occurs. Don't stage both optional fights simply to use all prepared content.

# Outcomes and follow-through

**A wonder to carry forward:** Rask's Hostel emergency locker contains a **Pocket Dawn**, recognizable from its illuminated breathing-space label and the hostel checklist. He offers its use for the rescue and entrusts it to the crew afterward if they accept responsibility for future rescues. Teach the unfolding gesture during ten peaceful minutes before activation; it costs 1 Conviction and unfolds an anchored breathable refuge for up to four occupants for a watch, even in ordinary vacuum. One use per physical lantern per expedition; it is a readied relic, not armor or a healing source. See Wonders and discoveries. It can create refuge during an exterior approach or evacuation but does not transport residents, repair the station or fill an unrelated task clock. Its service mark names a reachable refuge-house host at the next port.

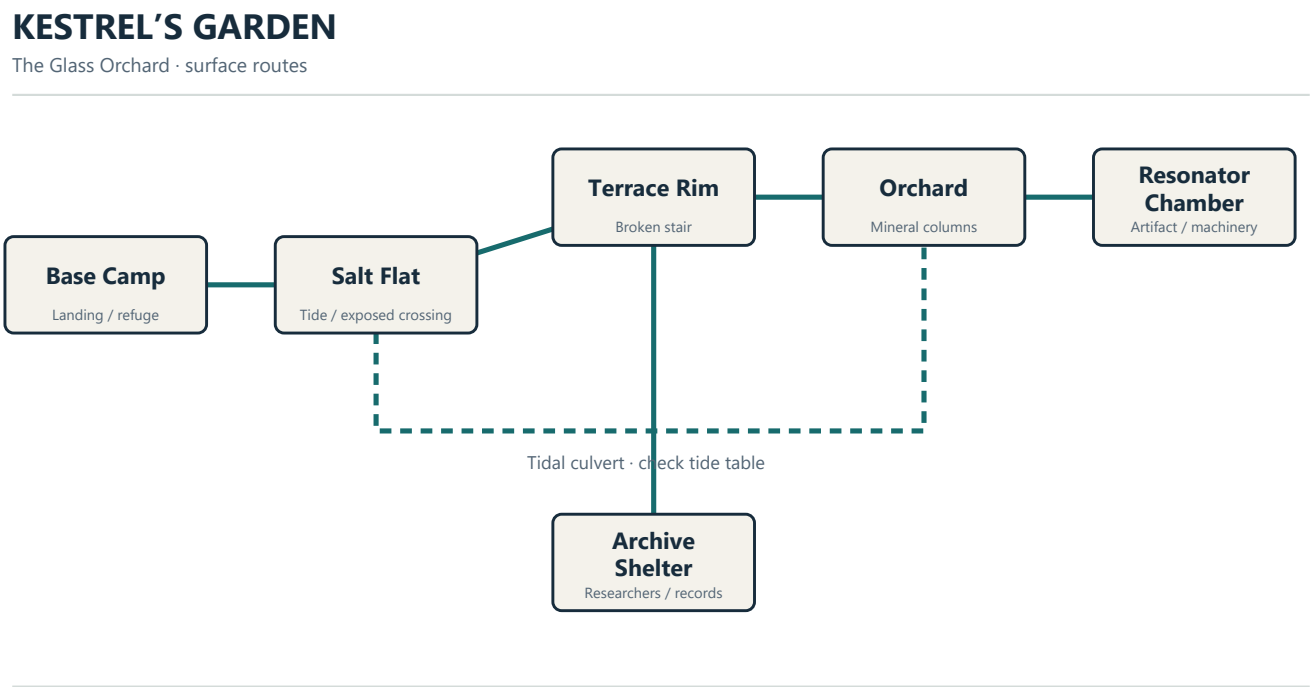
- Rescue/Power achieved: pay 4 Supply, immediately purchasable into Stores/gear before cap. If Power was completed, Rask also offers **one station service**: refill 1 Stores from emergency stock (maximum 6), restore 3 Hull, or repair one System Damage. Choose one, once for this rescue. It is not repeating downtime income. Evacuation without repair earns the same bond but leaves this station service unavailable.
- Registry restored: Quill withdraws the claim; agreeing to salvage destroyed parts gives her a reason to become a future contact.
- Memory case saved: Vesh gives the crew a Memory Seed already paired with the damaged record. Its replay shows a research team watching terraces light up on Kestrel's Garden, not proof of divinity.
- Residents evacuated but station not repaired: job succeeds; the station becomes a reachable reconstruction job. No mandatory territory upkeep.
- Evidence destroyed or residents threatened: relevant Trust falls by 1. Describe specific witnesses and consequences rather than universal hostility.

Award milestones for significant rescue/repair resolution, costly Creed/quest choice, and useful discovery, according to actual play. Offer two leads: a Kestrel's Garden survey contract or a missing-person inquiry at Meridian Anchorage. Ask what each PC wants from the next port. End with a working ship and options.

## Scaling and Guide notes

Two PCs: one guard; let Suri automatically contribute 1 Rescue progress once if asked. Four PCs: two guards maximum; no extra clock sizes. Duet: Rescue 2, Power 4, Registry 2; Reserve remains 6. Companion may brace, help and act at a ship station. If all PCs are Downed, Quill and Suri negotiate evacuation; establish loss of time or a debt rather than ending the campaign.

# Adventure II / The Glass Orchard




**Guide only · ranks 1-3 · 2-4 PCs · 2-3 hours**

On Kestrel's Garden, mineral terraces have begun transmitting patterned light. A survey sponsor offers **3 Supply and 2 ship Stores** for a safe record and atmosphere samples. Dr. An Varo wants the research crew recovered first. A competitor seeks to extract the resonator before knowing what it does. This is a proposed alien ecology/artifact story, not a declaration that a canon god made this world.

The crew may arrive from The Silent Berth or accept this as its first job. At Meridian, take two safe legs via buoy (2 Stores), or one dusty shortcut (1 Stores plus navigation roll as chapter 6). Starting ship Stores 4 supports either. The ship lands at Base Camp without a roll once the crew has a current scan, available from the survey contract or by scanning locally. Planetary air is breathable but terrace dust irritates lungs: sealed suits or Base Camp filters avoid exposure. One unprotected exploration watch gives 1 Strain, announced first.

## Map and clocks

Zones: **Base Camp -> Salt Flat -> Terrace Rim -> Orchard -> Resonator Chamber**. Add **Archive Shelter** connected to Terrace Rim. Two routes enter Orchard: Rim's broken stair (repair/rope task) or Salt Flat's tidal culvert (a watch of extra travel, safe when tide table is checked). The staircase is a 4-clock Traverse task; failure causes 1 Strain and a changed position, not a fall to certain death. A secured rope makes it automatically traversable after completion. Living Path can bypass one damaged stair but cannot replace the whole ascent unless that was the only obstruction.

Task clocks: **Research 0/6**, **Recovery 0/4**. Threat countdown **Extraction 0/4**, initially 0. Advance Extraction at the end of a watch while the competitor's team is actively operating in Chamber. Tell the crew via a visible work light and radio traffic. It does not advance merely because a PC speaks. Disabling the competitor's drill or securing a ceasefire stops it. At 4, the

competitor removes the resonator and prepares departure; the object is still recoverable through negotiation or interception, not erased from play.

There is no global conversion field or Zeal score. The phenomenon has physical effects and competing religious interpretations.

## NPCs

**Dr. An Varo:** gene-crafted human, secular Biotic researcher. Needs two field researchers returned and uncontaminated evidence. Offers filters and honest data, not ownership of the planet.

**Kelm Orr:** mechanical human, Ancients Wanderer and independent salvage specialist. Believes the resonator should remain in place but values the missing researchers more. Can share the tide table for free if told the rescue plan. His mechanical body does not give authority over the relic. His manifest lists a **sample vault**, which he loans if promised its return and one shared ordinary sample. Fit it during ten safe minutes. The vault preserves safely collected samples against a watch of ordinary vacuum/air contamination, not unknown collection hazards or extreme pressure. It is one physical field fitting, not free Supply or automatic Research progress. See Signature gear.

**Captain Iri Senn:** unmodified human, Order Architect, extraction contractor. Has a valid sponsor contract but incomplete environmental information. Will stop if shown credible evidence removal risks people or if given an equivalent paid sample contract. Religion is not why she is reckless; deadline pressure is.

**Field researchers:** Veyran cartographer Tel and human psionic trainee Mira, both alive in Archive Shelter with damaged comms. They disagree on whether the signal is purposeful. Neither can solve the entire mystery telepathically.

## Exploration and discoveries

At Base Camp give the crew three leads without rolls: researchers last reported at Rim; repeating light correlates with tide and vibration; competitor radio is active near Chamber. Each location provides evidence through inspection or conversation; rolls resolve hazards and deeper interpretation, never whether the adventure contains a clue.

**Salt Flat:** transparent plates vibrate with footsteps; the pattern matches a recorded old maintenance rhythm. Scanning reveals no life-sign equivalent to a humanoid. A hazardous crossing can be avoided with the tide table. Without it, Insight to predict or Finesse to follow high ground: partial 1 Strain, failure choose a watch delay or a damaged suit requiring a patch before further exposure.

**Terrace Rim:** tracks lead to Archive Shelter and drill marks toward Orchard. A physical sample shows that removing the resonator changes pressure in water-filled terraces. This is concrete evidence Senn will consider. Gathering it safely contributes to Research with ordinary task rolls; partial 1 progress or 2 and one watch's extra work; failure taints the sample and reveals a reachable alternate sampling point.

**Archive Shelter:** Tel and Mira need a replacement comm cell and a route down. Recovery 4-clock can be filled by repairing communications, organizing an escorted descent, treating a minor injury, or retrieving the emergency sled. Partial 1 progress, failure a watch delay. At completion both reach Camp safely; no mandatory enemy fight. A crew can escort them immediately through a secured route without rolling further: spend the necessary watch, then complete Recovery. Their recordings supply 2 Research progress once.

**Orchard:** columns resemble trees but are geological structures coated in microbial film. This is a discovery, not a hostile species. Tel's notes identify safe standing areas. A careless high-energy blast may cause a collapse: announce visibly unstable columns first. If triggered, everyone in Orchard defends Finesse against 2 damage using normal defense bands, then the stair route closes but culvert remains. The Guide never introduces this simply to punish curiosity.

**Resonator Chamber:** the object can be studied in place. A routine scanner reveals a powered environmental regulator; its makers and purpose beyond that remain unknown. Research reaches 6 through physical samples, data comparison, conversation, old records or a careful rite. Limit each unchanged approach to one roll; meaningful new evidence permits another. Completion establishes **removing the whole resonator destabilizes the terrace water, but a detachable memory core can be taken safely after a controlled shutdown**. Also reveal Quiet Glass coordinates in its maintenance record. No evidence proves one Pantheon right.

## Competing extraction

Senn shares the contract and her observations when hailed. If shown credible pressure evidence, she pauses for one watch without a roll. Research completion persuades her to the safe memory-core plan if the crew agrees to shared credit. A different bargain can work if it meets her need for a legitimate deliverable. Unsupported threats use Presence: partial she withdraws on condition of a witnessed compensation bond (one future favor), failure her guards secure Chamber.

If combat occurs use **one Engine Tender and one Rifle Guard for four PCs; one Rifle Guard for two PCs**. The Tender's action primarily works a separate Drill 0/4 task, +1 per action, rather than attacking. When Drill completes, Extraction advances 1 once and Drill resets. Do not also advance Extraction every round: its normal watch timing remains, avoiding double countdown. At least one guard gives warning; enemies protect equipment and accept withdrawal. An Artificer can disable the exposed drill automatically with their rank-3 talent, or any PC can work a 4-clock sabotage task using Insight/Force. No special Vocation is mandatory.

If Extraction reaches 4 before agreement, let the crew intercept the transport at Base Camp, offer the safer core plan, bargain for a shared survey or pursue the contractor later. Senn will return the object on credible evidence of imminent harm and a safe unloading plan. A portable core is the likely prize; a stolen planet-scale machine is not a pocket weapon.

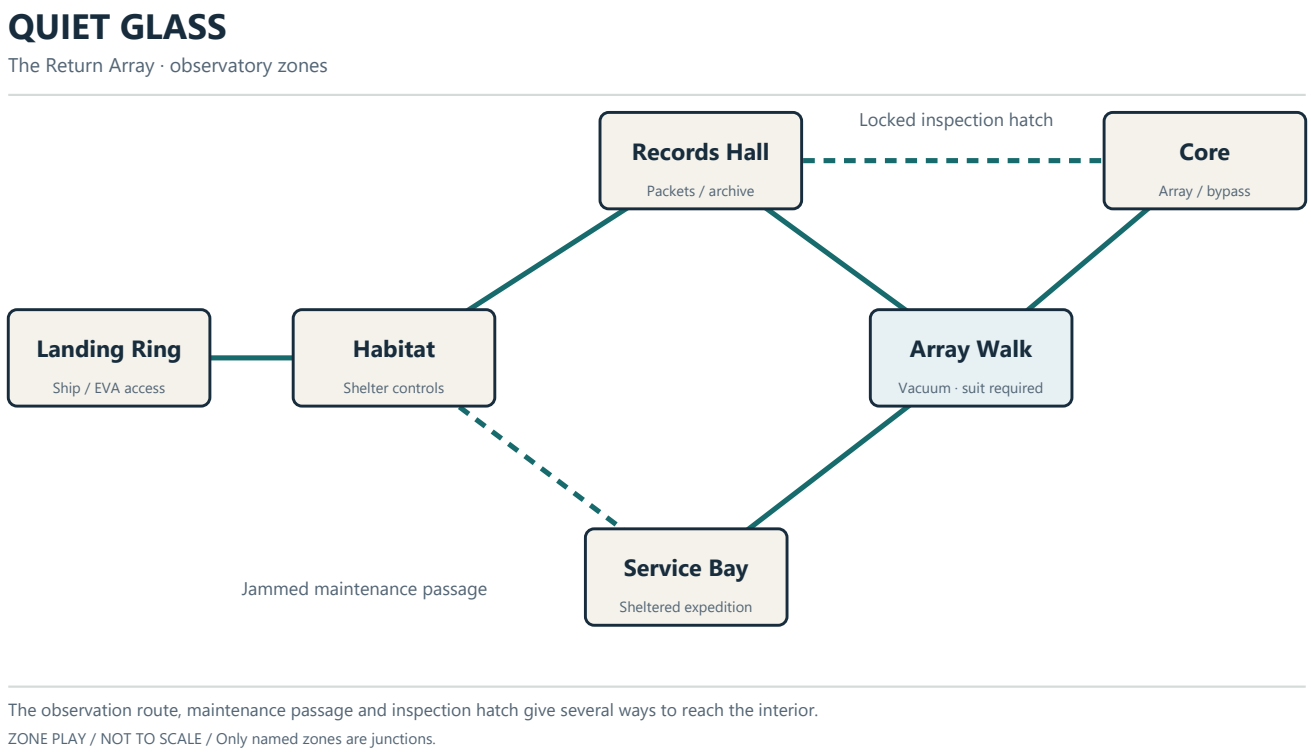
## Rewards and next adventures

Pay **3 Supply +2 Stores** for the valid survey, even if the core stays put. Researchers rescued earns +1 Trust with Base Camp and a safe berth for the visit. The recovered memory core is a compatible archive for Memory Seed and includes Quiet Glass coordinates; it has no combat power. Kelm offers one routine ship repair watch (+3 Hull or repair one System Damage) if the crew prevented unnecessary destruction.

Options afterward: follow coordinates to Quiet Glass; investigate the sponsor's pressure on Senn; accompany Tel to compare another world; deliver the findings to a temple, university or public archive. The crew decides who gets copies. Give secular scholarship and religious inquiry equally useful questions.

**Duet:** Traverse 2, Research 4, Recovery 2, Extraction countdown unchanged. One Rifle Guard only, no Tender. Kelm can hold the stair or advise but does not make player decisions. **Rank 3 group:** deepen the research question or negotiations; do not automatically add enemies for every level. Record pacing before adjusting.

# Adventure III / Quiet Glass




**Guide only · ranks 2-3, with rank-1 option · 2-4 PCs · 2-3 hours**

Quiet Glass is an old observatory on a cold moon. The crew has its coordinates from Kestrel's Garden, a copied station survey, or a public research charter. Its narrow-band transmitter is sending a missing expedition's distress call with sentences that crew members insist they have never recorded.

This adventure closes the opening Reach arc while leaving a wider universe available. It combines a mystery, environmental exploration, a possible supernatural encounter and a choice about an unusual artifact. The observatory's technology, makers and phenomena are original tabletop additions. Their existence does not prove any Pantheon correct.

## The actual situation

Prepare these facts and keep them consistent. Do not choose a new culprit in response to player theories.

1. The observatory's **Return Array** stores incoming radio/sensory patterns and models likely emergency traffic to guide long-range rescue. Its present malfunction combines real old calls with projected possible phrases. It is **not** an archive of souls or a machine that predicts everything.
2. A recent expedition activated it while seeking old navigation records. Two members, **Siv Arden** and **Nema Voss**, are alive in the sheltered Service Bay. A damaged sensor drone falsely reports their section empty.
3. The expedition erased a public approach log after the Array began rebroadcasting private medical conversations. The physical arrival evidence remains. The crew didn't erase its existence by magic.

4. A power feedback loop now threatens the archive and shelter. It has produced a hazardous **Echo** around the Core: a repeating energetic impression, not an established god or a character whose personhood must be denied to win. It can be dispersed, isolated or allowed to fade after shutdown.
5. The expedition's other two members departed in a shuttle to obtain replacement parts and will return after one fictional day unless the crew signals them sooner. They are not secretly dead by default.

## Arrival

From Kestrel's Garden one surveyed leg costs 1 Stores. From Meridian two legs cost 2. There is no public fuel at Quiet Glass; announce the cost of leaving before the crew departs. If the crew has insufficient Stores for a return, arrange a paid transport charter or reserve drum beforehand. No surprise fuel trap.

The Meridian survey charter pays **4 Supply and 2 Stores** for verified rescue status and a non-destructive record of the observatory, supplied by a service tender after the site is secure or collected on return. The crew can instead visit for a personal quest; the expedition will reimburse **2 Supply** for actual rescue work if a charter wasn't arranged. These rewards do not stack.

Read/paraphrase: “The moon turns slowly beneath a thin veil of dust. Above an unlit landing ring, a telescope follows a star no longer visible. Your receiver whispers, ‘Please don't open the inner door.’ The voice then identifies your ship correctly.”

A routine ship scan reveals a powered shelter, the Array's intermittent surges and a damaged landing beacon. The correct ship name was taken from its public transponder. Make this discoverable by checking logs; don't present it as proof of omniscience. Ordinary docking at the Ring is safe with suit use. An exterior antenna crossing is an optional EVA scene, never the only entrance.

## Map and pressure

Zones: **Landing Ring -> Habitat -> Records Hall -> Array Walk -> Core**. The **Service Bay** connects to Habitat and Array Walk through a jammed maintenance passage. Records Hall and Core also connect through a locked inspection hatch; its physical lock can be opened with tools in ten minutes if uncontested. The Array Walk is unpressurized; sealed suits or suitable Embodiment required. Other zones have breathable air until the power fails. Opaque walls block ranged attacks except through open connections.

Draw **Understanding 0/6**, **Safe Isolation 0/4**, and countdown **Feedback 0/6**. At the end of each exploration watch after arrival advance Feedback by 1. During tactical conflict near the Core advance it at each round end instead; do not also count that conflict's elapsed watch. A PC at Habitat controls can spend an action routing load to prevent one automatic round-end advance. This doesn't cancel failure costs. Safe Isolation completion stops the clock and the Echo.

At Feedback 3, announce that the Array Walk will discharge next round if anyone enters conflict there. Its hazard is 2 Guard damage defended by Finesse using normal defense outcomes, once at the next round end; then the Walk's lights burn out. At Feedback 6, the Array loses power: the unprotected historical archive suffers a data loss, everyone in Core moves to Array Walk or Records Hall at their choice and takes 2 damage, and shelter batteries provide one watch of air. Nobody is automatically killed or trapped. A recovered physical memory core retains the current expedition's record even if old records are lost.

## People, impressions and what they know

**Siv Arden:** unmodified human, psionically trained Witness, Divinity Listener tradition. Knows the Array can remix private speech; wants the others' consent before releasing recordings. A short willing thought exchange is possible through a visible open connection, not telepathy across the moon.

**Nema Voss:** Nacrean, augmented Artificer, secular. Has splinted a leg, can walk with help, and understands the power manifold. Wants the site shut down safely before someone calls it a miracle and runs more tests.

**The Echo:** repeats three fragments: “hold the passage,” “tell them we were here,” and “not without asking.” Those are archived phrases from real rescue work. The Guide may describe uncanny behavior, but must not claim it reads the PCs' thoughts. Its observable activity is energetic: static, light, vibration and a directed pulse when approached. It has no compulsory speaking personality.

The absent shuttle crew are **Rill** (mechanical human pilot, Ancients) and **Toma** (Oruun surveyor, Order). Their repair request is on a public channel, providing another way to learn the expedition exists.

## Three reliable clue routes

| Question | Physical evidence | Person or alternate source |
|---|---|---|
| Did an expedition really arrive? | Fresh docking abrasion and four suit locker entries at Landing Ring | Shuttle crew's repair request or Siv's badge |
| Why do the logs contradict the message? | Records Hall has an explicit deletion request tied to privacy; backup timestamp survives | Siv explains the rebroadcast, or compare raw transmitter packets |
| What must be shut down? | Power labels show the manifold feeding both shelter and Array; an inspection diagram marks the isolation bypass | Nema explains the bypass, or an ordinary scanner traces the load |

Give core evidence on inspection or conversation. Rolls resolve dangerous access, recovering richer context or speeding work under pressure. No required clue is hidden behind one successful roll, one Vocation or a religious interpretation.

## 1. Habitat: the call and the sheltered crew

Habitat has a kettle, half-finished survey models, travel shrines from two traditions, a secular medical locker and handwritten notes about a shared meal. The researchers expected to return. A status panel marks Service Bay empty, but an ordinary listen at its door detects tapping; Echo Sense or scanner identifies movement as well.

The maintenance passage is jammed, not magically sealed. Clearing it is a 4-clock task using Force to free the track, Insight to bypass a lock, or Finesse to reach the manual release. Partial 1 progress or 2 and 1 Strain; failure +1 Feedback. Alternatively open the Records inspection hatch and reach Service Bay from Array Walk, avoiding the jam but requiring suits. Nema can direct the final release for +1 progress once after communication. Once open, the pair can be escorted safely to Habitat or the ship. This rescue does not require the rest of the mystery to be solved.

An Envoy can establish what Siv will share: technical data and rescue status immediately, private patient conversations only in redacted form. The crew may accept that distinction without a roll. Pressure, evidence or a threat can change access but cannot force anyone's genuine religious interpretation.

## 2. Records Hall: meaningful research

Understanding 6-clock represents learning how the Array models/repeats messages and identifying its safe bypass. Approaches include comparing raw packets (Insight/Records), tracing power (Insight/Machinery), reconstructing physical events (Finesse/Watchfulness when relevant), interviewing the researchers (Presence) or interpreting an observable rite-like phenomenon with a useful power. The site is not automatically a rite; Unmask alone doesn't turn off its machinery.

Partial 1 progress or 2 with a watch's delay; failure reveals a misleading software label and costs a watch, with evidence explaining the correction. The Guide does not give a false factual answer and expect players to guess it was fabricated. Nema's informed explanation provides 2 progress once if rescued; raw backup and live packet comparison can each contribute through meaningful actions. Repeat rolls require new evidence or a changed method.

At completion reveal all five situation facts that the gathered evidence can support, except private details not needed for the task. The oldest archive also shows that the observatory used several languages, disproving the easy assumption that one modern species built it alone. Its makers remain an open historical mystery.

## 3. Core: isolate or confront

At Core the Echo pulses whenever the feedback amplifier charges. Announce its position and the safe waiting zone. The crew may:

- **Isolate safely:** work Safe Isolation 4-clock by separating shelter and Array feeds. With Understanding complete and tools, no roll is needed if no immediate danger opposes the work: spend one watch and complete it. Before Understanding, risky attempts use Insight/Force; partial 1 progress or 2 and 1 Stores in salvaged ship parts, failure +1 Feedback. A protective rite can help crew withstand the environment, not substitute for understanding every circuit.
- **Cut power immediately:** one action at the exposed master disconnect. Stops the Array/Echo and advances shelter air to its one-watch backup; old unsaved records are lost. Safe rescue remains possible. This is a real tradeoff, not secretly the “wrong” ending.
- **Disperse the Echo:** use the Unbound Echo leader profile from chapter 4, no additional regular enemies. It remains in Core and never pursues someone leaving to safety. At Guard 0 it fades, granting time for ordinary isolation; it reforms after one watch if the amplifier remains active. Successful Unmask can suppress its Strain pulse until the caster's next turn because that pulse is the scenario's explicit rite-like effect; it doesn't suppress the entire creature or the station.
- **Use the protocol:** a rescued Siv can provide the repetition's original rescue-channel code. Broadcasting that code requires an action at Records Hall, then one at Core. It prevents the Echo's next two activations, giving space to work without dealing damage. Tell players that concrete effect when Siv explains the evidence.

For rank-1 crews replace Echo Guard 6 with Guard 4, damage 1, and keep its Strain pulse at 1. Four PCs may use the standard leader. No other foe spawns because the crew succeeds.

## 4. What to take and what to leave

Once safe, offer three recoverable things:

1. **Return Chart:** a nonmagical archive of three reachable route leads. Choose Serev, Pelara or a Hearth rendezvous as the next destination; existing public route costs remain valid. Its restricted historical layer is future research, not a free portal anywhere.
2. **Listening Prism:** once per scene, action +1 Conviction, separate one known voice from a noisy recording in your zone, provided a real recording exists. It does not hear live minds, reconstruct deleted content without a trace, or prove a speaker truthful. This is a new relic with explicit limits.
3. **Expedition records:** rescue status, public science and private conversations can be copied separately. Siv agrees to public science and redacted rescue records; the private material stays with its subjects unless players make a different choice and face specific consequences.

A religious PC may recognize themes from the Listener, Cartographer or Remembering Sea. A secular PC may emphasize engineering and consent. Let that generate a conversation and future invitations; don't award exclusive mission success to one belief.

## Ending the arc

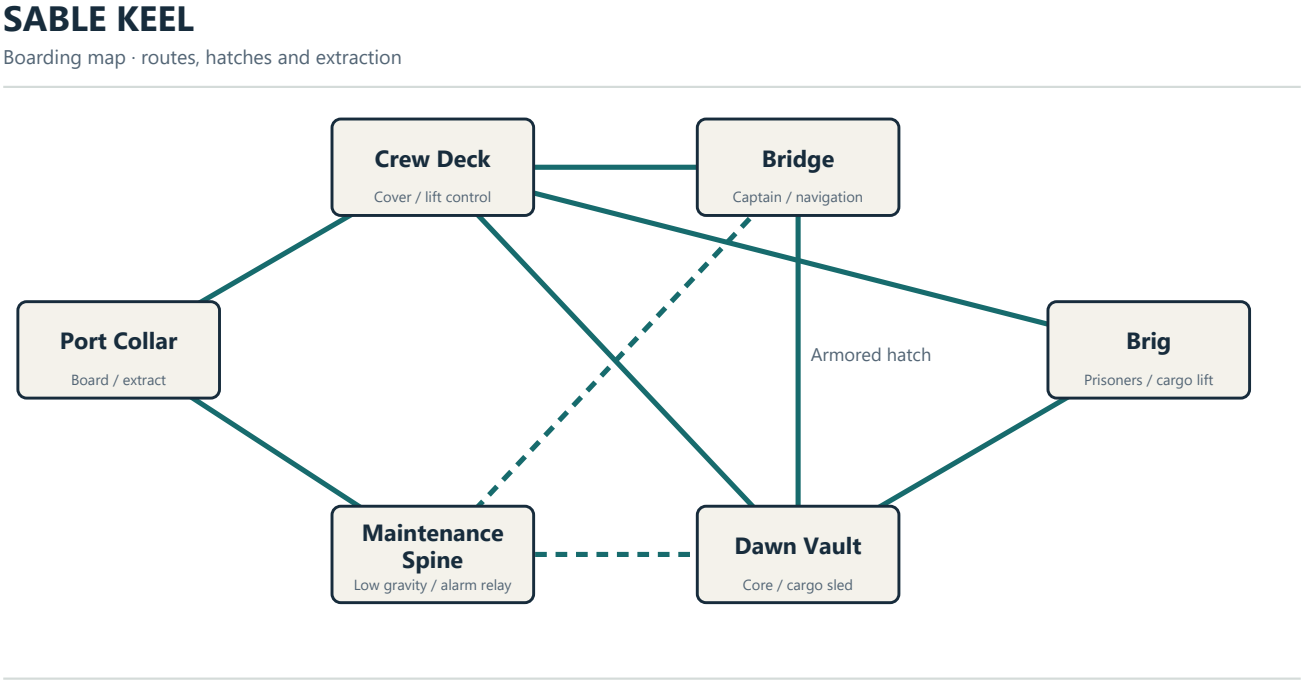
Return the missing expedition or establish a safe shelter and contact with its shuttle: rescue succeeds. Document the site non-destructively: charter science condition succeeds. If archive power was cut, rescue still earns the charter but research records may be incomplete; the patron offers the full reward for honest reporting rather than incentivizing lies. If a charter wasn't arranged, use the rescue reimbursement instead.

Pay the stated reward once; refuel from the service tender or at a real port, not an unexplained cache. The tender's 2 Stores reward is available only after contact and site security; retain enough for a return before relying on it. Survivors become contacts, and the next destination comes from the crew's interests: a human continuity dispute, a Veyran sensor controversy, an Oruun rescue or Nacrean archaeology.

**Consequences:** copied private records may harm named people and lower Trust; keeping the archive safe can win a researcher introduction; destroying it may end one dangerous technology but leave open historical questions. No ending automatically converts a community, claims the moon or adds a mandatory political phase.

**Duet:** passage task 2, Understanding 4, Safe Isolation 2; Feedback countdown stays 6. Use rank-1 Echo, and let Siv's code suppress three activations instead of two. Companion can operate the second console. A player can choose immediate shutdown and rescue without a fight. If crew is defeated, the arriving repair shuttle provides evacuation at the cost of lost equipment/time; ask which ordinary item or opportunity they leave behind, not which identity they surrender.

# Adventure IV / Raid on the Sable Keel




**Guide only · ranks 3-5 · 2-4 PCs · 2-3 hours · boarding, tactics and escape**

A pirate frigate has taken a habitat's Dawncore, a portable energy cell that keeps its winter shelter heated. The frigate **Sable Keel** is crossing a debris belt before selling the core to a remote buyer. A rescue captain offers the crew **4 Supply, 2 Stores and a ship module** for returning it before the next cold cycle. This is a direct adventure against an armed pirate crew, with infiltration, deception and negotiation available alongside a fight.

The habitat can protect its people in communal shelters for two days. The deadline makes choices matter without a surprise mass casualty if one roll fails. A missed recovery creates a harder rescue/supply mission rather than ending the campaign. Dawncore is cargo, not a pocket-sized planet-destroying weapon.

## Before departure

The captain supplies the frigate's route, a compatible boarding collar on loan, a salvage transponder and a rendezvous for returning. The route is one local surveyed leg lasting one watch from Meridian or another named port; spend 1 Stores. The return is another watch/leg, leaving a clear margin inside the two-day shelter window. Reserve enough to get home. The promised 2 Stores arrives at the recovery rendezvous, not magically in the ship's tank when someone grabs the core.

Offer three approaches with known costs:

- **Disguised service call:** transmit the salvage transponder and claim a repair inspection. Presence to hold the deception while approaching: partial accepted but escorted, failure questioned at Engagement 2 with a chance to show an alternative bargain or withdraw. No automatic free pirate shot.

- **Debris-belt approach:** Insight/Spacecraft navigation gives an unobserved external docking point. Partial take 1 Hull damage or a watch delay; failure enter a pursuit at Engagement 1 with the pirates aware. The belt is a real place, not universal invisibility.
- **Open interception:** start a ship scene at Engagement 1. Sable Keel's local defense is represented by a patrol-cutter profile (Hull 8, damage 3); it wants to reach its buyer and may trade custody of the core for a believable payment/escape arrangement. If disabled, it can be boarded without destroying its residents.

If approach succeeds, dock at **Port Collar**; an external approach can instead enter **Maintenance Spine** with suits and one secured rig. The protagonists' ship remains the extraction route. Don't destroy it offscreen to force the prepared ending.

## Map

Six zones: **Port Collar**, **Crew Deck**, **Brig**, **Maintenance Spine**, **Dawn Vault**, **Bridge**.

- Collar connects to Crew Deck and Spine.
- Crew Deck connects to Brig, Vault and Bridge.
- Spine connects to Vault and Bridge through narrow service hatches.
- Brig connects to Vault through a heavy cargo lift that needs power.
- Vault connects to Bridge through an armored hatch.

Vault/Bridge walls block sight; open hatches grant normal adjacent-zone range. Crew Deck has cover. Spine is low gravity with handholds; suits/anchors permit ordinary movement. A bulky Dawncore occupies two cargo slots and needs a sled or two conscious carriers to move at normal speed. One carrier alone uses an action plus move for each connection, leaving no action to attack that turn.

Two carriers must begin together. On one carrier's activation both can commit their **unused normal moves for this round** to move the core and both bodies one connection; mark the second carrier's move spent when they later activate. Neither gains another action. Each has one hand/interface occupied while carrying, so a two-handed bulky weapon or fine two-handed tool work is unavailable until the core is set down. An ally who already spent their move cannot help another haul until the next round. A sled instead lets one carrier use their normal move. An escorted freed prisoner may help carry outside immediate danger; under fire they need actual coordination and a safe route.

**Three useful controls:** a Crew Deck console opens the Brig lift; a Spine switch interrupts the alarm relay; the Vault's local lock accepts its physical key or a successful 4-progress bypass. Controls have visible labels once inspected. Core clues never require the Artificer specifically.

## People and motives

**Captain Daska Venn:** mechanical human, Order Dissenter, former convoy officer. She runs an armed theft operation and knows the core's owner needs it. She wants payment and a viable exit; appeals to her Pantheon alone won't erase her choice. Use Astral Duelist (Guard 6, armor 0, damage 2 close) with a damage-2 ranged sidearm as an alternate ordinary attack. She has one action, not both attacks each turn.

**Bo Renn:** gene-crafted human, secular cargo engineer. Dislikes harming civilians but stays for pay and fear of Daska. Knows how to release the core safely. A credible offer of passage out and protection earns his technical help; no forced conversion or loyalty roll. If pressured into remaining a pirate, he may still warn the crew of danger.

**Ish Vale:** unmodified human, Ancients observer, captured convoy pilot in Brig. Wants the other two prisoners out too. Can fly the protagonists' ship if the crew needs everyone at the collar, but doesn't gain a hidden independent combat turn.

**The buyers:** a small group calling itself the **Furnace Covenant**. Their payment channel and a gathering coordinate are in the Bridge; they are an original future antagonist hook, not a new mandatory religion or a declaration that all engineered people are villains.

## Patrols and alarm

Start with **two Boarding Specialists for four PCs, one for two PCs**, divided between Crew Deck and Vault. Use chapter 4. Off-duty crew are ordinary people who flee or shelter once the alarm sounds; they do not become a surprise army. Daska begins at Bridge. In a direct shootout use her plus the listed specialists; in infiltration she remains a separate obstacle until the crew exposes itself.

Draw **Escape Window 0/6**, a countdown that begins only when the ship-wide alarm is raised or the core leaves Vault. Advance it once at the end of each tactical round during the alarm, or once per risky extended scene outside rounds. Announce each advance as the frigate turning toward its guarded rendezvous. At 6, a buyer skiff reaches Engagement 1 outside, presenting a new pursuit/bargain; it doesn't teleport troops into every zone.

A specialist may spend its action raising the alarm at an intact terminal. The protagonists can stop that action, disable the relay with an Insight/Force 4-clock task in Spine, or isolate it with a suitable visible power. A failure on an unrelated roll does not automatically sound an alarm the NPC never used an action to trigger. A noisy explosive can legitimately alert the ship-announce that before use.

## Encounters and opportunities

### 1. Crew Deck: choose a route

A guard checks the crew's service story while the other visible activity is a card game and a meal. Infiltration can proceed with an escort if the story plausibly matches the transponder. Inspecting the console reveals the Brig lift and alarm status. Read the Room can identify Bo as the person who knows the cargo procedure; ordinary conversation can learn the same.

If a fight starts, the nearest specialist tries to raise the alarm on its first action rather than also attacking. Cover protects someone who spends an action taking it; firing exposes them normally. A Wayrunner can take Spine, an Envoy can split the escort, and a Bulwark can keep a hatch open. These are options, not required solutions.

### 2. Brig: a rescue choice

Ish and two cargo workers are behind an ordinary barred hatch. The visible key is on the local guard's ring; taking it requires an actual approach, not an automatic disarm of every item. Force/tools can open the hatch as a 4-clock task; partial 1 progress or 2 +1 Strain, failure an alarm attempt becomes possible to an alerted guard. If no guard remains and no time pressure is active, ordinary tools and ten minutes suffice.

Prisoners can follow a safe route once released. A rescue sled from the ship can carry an injured worker; otherwise one crew member assists them and cannot use a bulky weapon while doing so. Rescue is optional to the paid objective but creates a real Creed/personal choice and useful contacts.

### 3. Dawn Vault: extract the core

The core is held by four mechanical clamps with a labeled release manifold. Bo can demonstrate the procedure: spend one action at the correct local control, then one at the cargo sled. Without him, a 4-clock Insight/Force task releases it. Partial 1 progress or 2 and spend 1 Supply on a field adapter; failure causes a visible arc, defended once against 2 damage by everyone in Vault, then that section of machinery is safe to approach. Don't repeat the same arc every miss without a new powered cause.

A copied maintenance record proves which habitat the core serves and shows a second theft from a Hearth vessel. It is a lead, not a mandatory hidden explanation for why all pirates are secretly innocent. The core can be returned or exchanged; selling it to the buyer for more money is possible but has concrete consequences for the habitat and the crew's commitments.

### 4. Bridge: Daska and the choice to stay

Daska will bargain over a captured core, prisoners or evidence that her buyer plans to seize her ship. She isn't persuaded merely by a good speech with no leverage. A believable exit can end her resistance; an unsupported threat may start combat. If defeated or her ship is clearly disabled, she attempts surrender or escape rather than dying for the buyer. If the crew chooses a fight, her duelist route action can stop the core carriers while her specialist uses the alarm-state these goals openly.

At half the active pirate fighters Downed, the remaining specialists withdraw toward Bridge. Daska may hold Bridge alone to negotiate her exit; announce her changed stance rather than secretly canceling morale. A crew that already has core and prisoners need not chase her for an arbitrary kill reward.

## Extraction and aftermath

Reach Collar with the core and a clear docking route to extract. If a buyer skiff has arrived, run one ship scene with salvage-skiff statistics (Hull 4, damage 2); it demands custody, not a battle to extinction. A disabled Sable Keel isn't also firing full-strength volleys in the same abstracted encounter. The crew can flee, bargain, disable pursuit or surrender disputed cargo and pursue a later recovery.

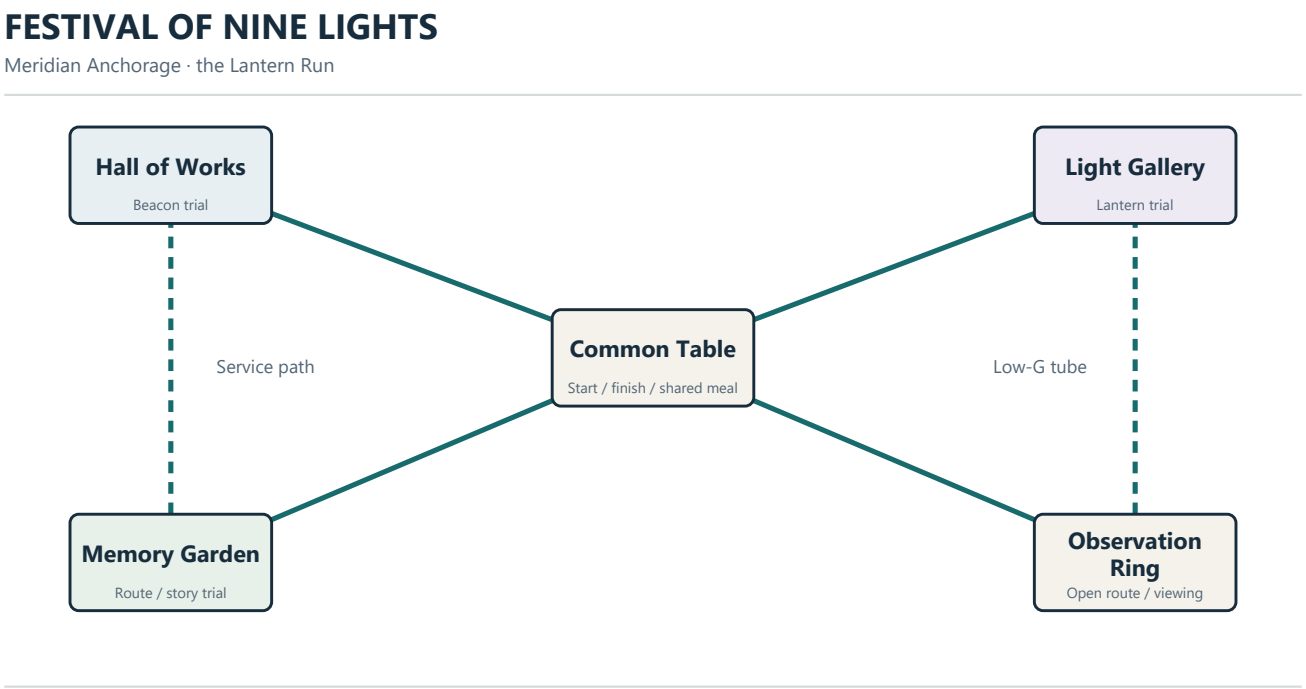
Return the core: pay **4 Supply +2 Stores +one chosen ordinary ship module**, installed at a safe yard during downtime and subject to the three-module/frame limits. The module isn't another cash payout if declined. Prisoners rescued grants a named contact and +1 Trust with their convoy; don't add a second free milestone beyond the normal session criteria.

Failure to return in time leaves the habitat operating communal shelters. Offer an evacuation/supply job whose difficulty reflects the delay. Returning late can still help. The buyer's coordinate leads to a Sun-Eater Engine installation, a new human faction story, or an independent crew's next adventure. Nothing forces the campaign into Zeal control.

### Scaling

For duet use one specialist, Daska stays at Bridge unless directly confronted, and bypass/release clocks are 2. Escape Window stays 6. Ish can operate the ship once freed. For four rank-5 PCs, use two specialists and Daska as written plus a visible moving core objective; test that scene before adding another enemy. A stealth success can skip the fight entirely without reducing the mission's value.

# Interlude / Festival of Nine Lights




**Guide only · any rank, designed for ranks 1-4 · 2-4 PCs · 90 minutes to 2 hours · celebration, teamwork and roleplaying**

Meridian Anchorage's annual festival fills the dock with food stalls, performances, temporary gardens, repair booths, ancestor recordings and a spectacular lantern run through low gravity. Order, Ancients and Divinity communities organize it together with secular port associations. People attend to worship, compete, meet family, find work or simply enjoy a good evening.

This is a complete low-violence interlude, not a massacre waiting to happen. Keep real danger under control unless the group has chosen a darker campaign event beforehand. The festival can introduce religious activity positively and give crew members reasons to care about the Reach between expeditions.

## Arriving and choosing a purpose

At Meridian there is no travel leg. Elsewhere, use ordinary route costs. Lodging is publicly sponsored for the night; one safe rest costs no Supply. Each player names one reason to attend: honor a figure, visit a contact, show off a new body, find a specialist, pursue a personal lead or compete. Introduce one reachable person relevant to each answer.

The main event is the **Lantern Run**, a cooperative team contest through three symbolic challenges. The prize is a Waylight relic, one research/temple introduction of the team's choice and free dock fees for this visit (no automatic Stores or indefinite free repairs). The runner-up still gets a friendly introduction; losing doesn't lock the crew out of the setting.

# Map and event rules

Zones: **Common Table** at center, connected to **Hall of Works**, **Memory Garden**, **Light Gallery** and **Observation Ring**. Hall and Garden connect through a service path; Gallery and Ring connect by a transparent low-gravity tube. Ring returns to Common Table. Everyone begins at Common Table with a team lantern.

The Run uses rounds, one ordinary move/action per participant, crew-chosen activation order, **no enemy phase**. The rival team's pace is represented by a visible **Festival Bell countdown**. For 2 PCs set three trial tasks at **4 progress each** and Bell **0/7**; for 3-4 PCs set trials at **6 each** and Bell **0/6**. For duet use **2 each**, Bell **0/7**, companion present. Advance Bell once at each round end. Finish all three tasks and return the lantern to Common Table before the final bell to win; completing on the final round before its end counts.

One PC may make a progress attempt at each trial each round; others can Help, fetch a relevant tool, plan a route or move the lantern. A single action cannot both advance a task and Help another roll. Partial gives 1 progress, full 2, exceptional 3. A failure gives no progress and 1 Strain from effort, with a visible misstep the character can learn from. There is no surprise bodily wound for losing a friendly contest. Failed approaches can be changed; a repetition with no new method earns no reroll.

Rites and class tools can genuinely solve parts of a trial. If an automatic power directly solves an announced physical subproblem, its action contributes 1 progress once for that subproblem, instead of also rolling for extra progress. It doesn't auto-complete a whole religious/cultural event. Describe what remains for other teammates to do. The field is designed for different bodies and abilities, not as a test of one species' anatomy.

# Three trials

### Hall of Works - keep the beacon working

A large rotating model demonstrates how a rescue beacon routes energy between two differently loaded habitats. One lens is deliberately misaligned and a handwheel needs support while a conductor is reset. Force can hold/adjust the wheel, Insight can route energy, Finesse can seat the lens or Presence can coordinate a mixed-language work team. Pick a real part of the process for each attempt. Machinery or relevant Improvisation can apply; merely touching a prop doesn't add every expertise.

**Host:** Dov Mera, augmented human, Order, a patient teacher who enjoys watching unconventional solutions. Once before a roll, asking a sincere technical question reveals the actual fault and gives a useful changed approach; it is not another bonus beyond normal Help/edge rules.

### Memory Garden - carry a story accurately

Physical route tokens, voices and old images describe a voyage with several surviving accounts. The team reconstructs where three ships separated and reunited. The story deliberately includes disagreement about motive; the objective is a supported route, not a single official interpretation. Insight/Records compares accounts, Finesse arranges the physical map, Presence interviews performers, and Routes can help identify a viable connection.

**Host:** Sesh Lio, Veyran, Ancients, a comic storyteller whose jokes change in each language. Echo Sense may identify where a physical token slid under a platform, but cannot read the story from a host's mind. The host offers the missing factual clue freely if the team asks; the risky part is completing the reconstruction under time pressure.

### Light Gallery - get the lantern across

A small low-gravity course requires moving a delicate ceremonial lantern through an open curved frame while keeping three spotters coordinated. Finesse steers, Force controls the anchor line, Insight calibrates the frame or Presence calls the sequence. Boots, tethers and accessible controls are provided. A clever psionic or mechanical solution is welcome; it must still respect the lantern's path and the rest of the process.

**Host:** Enna Sol, mechanical human, Divinity, a former rescue pilot. She asks before adapting the interface to a visitor's body. A Wayrunner can use the transparent tube; a Bulwark can hold an anchor; an Envoy can coordinate spotters; a Votary can offer a meaningful rite. No Vocation is required.

## Rivals and ordinary festival life

**Copper Sun** is the other leading team: gene-crafted human pilot Ter, mechanical human Votary Iss, and Nacrean researcher Pell. They want to win and remain friendly. They can exchange advice before the race, ask for a tool afterward, or become recurring expedition rivals. Their pace is Bell, not secret dice or extra turns. If a rule needs changing for safety, Dov pauses the event for both teams rather than punishing the person who raised the issue.

Between event rounds, brief cheering and conversation are free. Afterward give each character one spotlight scene:

- Share a meal, song or memory with someone from a different tradition.
- Attend a naming/reconstruction celebration in which the participant defines their own continuity.
- Visit the Cartographer's public chart exchange and choose a new route lead.
- Debate whether a damaged relic should be restored, studied, used or returned.
- Ask an ordinary scholar, medic, performer or captain about a personal quest.
- Observe privately, celebrate a secular custom, or invite friends to a practice from home.

If the player describes ten peaceful minutes of actual observance, use chapter 7's activity benefit instead of also awarding every downtime reward. Treat the Run as one continuous scene for once/scene limits; changing trial stations does not refresh them. A safe night's rest follows it, and a new expedition requires genuine departure/resupply as normal.

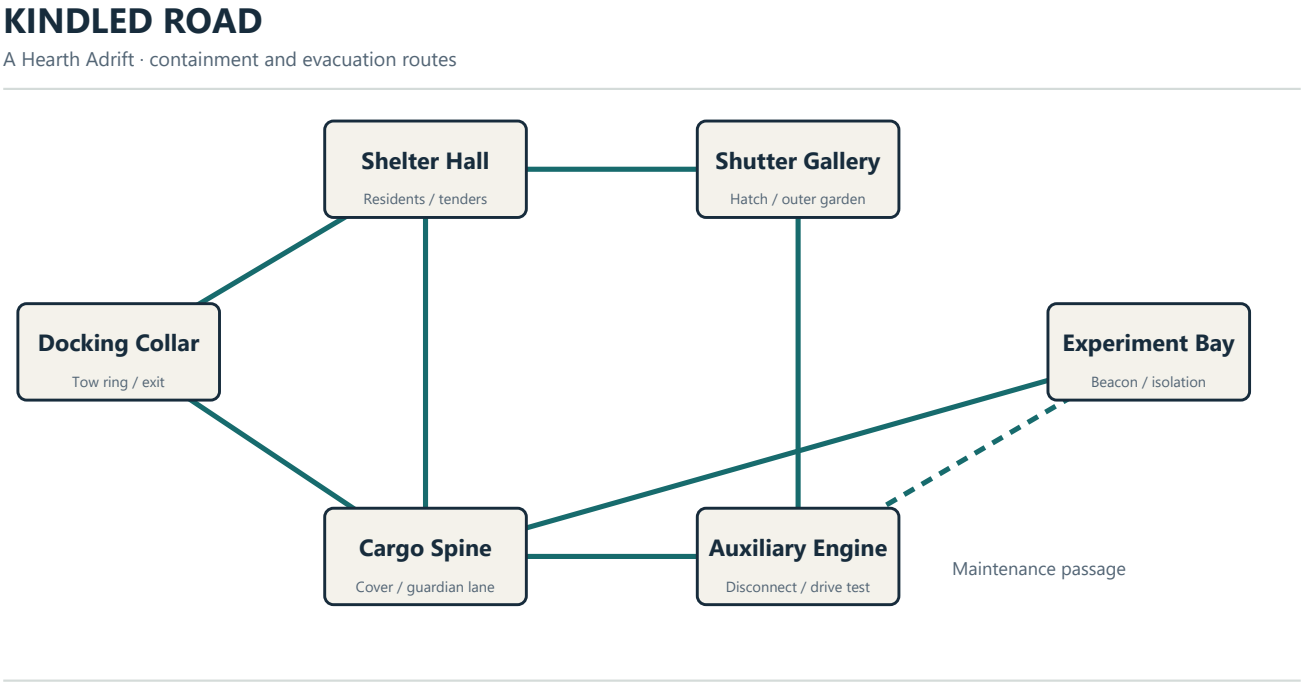
## Outcomes

Winning grants the stated Waylight and introduction. A team that misses Bell completes its trials publicly after the race and receives a contact as runner-up. Everyone can enjoy the observances and obtain a factual personal-quest lead from a suitable person; nobody must profess belief for ordinary hospitality.

Award a milestone for a significant team objective if it actually mattered, another for a genuinely costly Creed/quest choice if one occurred, and another for a discovery changing the crew's plan. A pleasant scene need not manufacture danger or sacrifice to earn all three. Let the players choose where the new contacts point: a boarding rescue, a distant people's invitation, a relic expedition or their own unfinished business.

The festival remains a living place afterward. Its hosts can be contacted, visited and disappointed, helped and argued with. Religious activity is a source of adventure, fellowship and identity rather than a meter that must be filled.

# Adventure V / A Hearth Adrift




**Guide only · suggested ranks 6-8 · 2-4 PCs · 3-4 hours · ship approach, rescue and containment**

The migrating habitat **Kindled Road** has lost propulsion beside a surveyed radiation lane. Ninety-six residents are sheltering behind its old storm shutters. A portable route-beacon experiment is still drawing energy from the engines. It can be isolated, evacuated or abandoned; no character needs a particular Discipline to do so. Advanced characters have more ways to help, not a higher numerical lock on every door.

Captain Ora Kel offers **3 Supply, 2 Stores and a fleet repair contact** for securing a safe outcome. Saving the people earns the reward even if the experiment is destroyed. Recovering the experiment without the people does not. The public request includes an accurate diagram, the known radiation boundary and the captain's permission to dock. There is no mandatory negotiation roll to accept a rescue call.

## Before departure

From Meridian Anchorage, take one local leg of one watch and spend 1 Stores. Return is another local leg/watch to the same receiving port. The rescue tender at that port can provide 2 Stores on credit if needed, repaid from the promised 2 Stores; this is an explicit option before departure, not surprise fuel debt. A compatible boarding collar and four pressure-rated tether rigs are available on loan. Ordinary sealed suits are sufficient inside the surviving habitat, not in an active radiation lane.

Give three facts immediately:

- Kindled Road can survive the radiation boundary for **one watch** with shutters closed; afterward it must be evacuated or moved.

- The experiment's containment pod is intact. Detaching its engine feed permits towing the habitat, but leaves the beacon without its normal power source.
- Ninety-six people exceed the protagonists' ship's bunks/cargo capacity. They need Kindled Road's own tenders, a stable tow, or outside help. Do not turn people into abstract ordinary cargo slots.

The experiment transmits a short tonal pattern. Ancients pilgrims hear a familiar departure cadence; Order engineers identify a synchronization protocol; Divinity listeners compare it to an old observance. These interpretations can coexist. A sensor reading establishes what it does, not which interpretation is universally true.

## What actually happened

The Furnace Covenant lent engineer **Beren Taal** a beacon assembly intended to improve route warnings. Beren knowingly connected it to the habitat's engine bus, but was given an incorrect heat budget. A surge locked the bus contactor and disabled propulsion. The Covenant's local liaison has requested the beacon's return, but has no hidden remote detonation or authority over the residents.

This accident can expose negligent research practices without making every Covenant worker a secret murderer. The damaged contactor, the original heat-budget file and Beren's handwritten measurements are three independent pieces of evidence. None requires memory-reading or a god's intervention. The original file also identifies a receiving laboratory for a later mission.

## Arrival and clocks

The habitat begins at Engagement 1, Hull 10, propulsion disabled. Hull loss is not its primary countdown; rescue depends on the following visible clocks. The Guide names the active time scale before each phase.

| Clock | Start | Advance / completion |
|---|---|---|
| **Drift** | 2/6 on arrival | Once at the end of each approach ship round; then once per work watch aboard. Never both for the same elapsed period. At 6 the habitat enters the radiation lane |
| **Isolation** | 0/6 | Task progress at the experiment, engine bus or both. At 6 the feed is safely detached and the habitat can accept an ordinary tow |
| **Evacuation** | 0/4 | Task organizing two functioning habitat tenders and their passengers. At 4 all residents can depart on a receiving route; no one is left because their body differs |

Failure on a task does **not** automatically advance Drift on top of its regular time advance. Use the concrete stated task consequence instead. A visible dangerous action can cost additional time only when announced before the roll. On reaching Drift 6, resolve a warning and close the shutters; start one remaining work watch of shelter. No sudden unannounced mass death follows a single miss.

### Approach with the crew ship

The habitat cooperates and takes no hostile ship action. Maneuver toward Engagement 3 using normal station rules; compatible docking is automatic once there because Ora authorizes it. A safe guided approach can instead take **one Drift step total** without rolls: Ora's tender places a line and brings the crew alongside. Offer this first. Ship rounds matter if the crew tries to save that time, dock on the far side or address an actual obstacle.

On a risky close approach, one loose cargo spar occupies the Docking Collar. A scan identifies it without a roll at ordinary range. Moving it is a four-progress station task using a tug line, a remote manipulator or an outside suited worker. It is a separate objective from Maneuver; one PC cannot do both with one action. The crew can use the safe guided approach around it. A task failure snaps a sacrificial line, costing 1 Stores to replace or forcing the slower route; it doesn't automatically impale the ship.

At Engagement 3 a visible insulated tow ring is available, but towing before Isolation completes would overload the contactor. Announce that risk. A master Mechanist's fail-safe can negate one qualifying System Damage; it does not complete Isolation or create an engine.

## Map and local time

Six zones: **Docking Collar**, **Shelter Hall**, **Cargo Spine**, **Experiment Bay**, **Auxiliary Engine**, **Shutter Gallery**.

- Collar connects to Shelter and Cargo Spine.
- Shelter connects to Cargo Spine and Shutter Gallery.
- Cargo Spine connects to Experiment Bay and Auxiliary Engine.
- Experiment Bay connects to Engine through a narrow maintenance passage.
- Engine connects to Shutter Gallery.

Closed radiation shutters block line of sight between Shelter and Gallery; their maintenance hatch remains traversable with a visible local latch. Thick walls prevent shooting through the maintenance passage. Cargo Spine has anchored cover and room for a rescue sled. Ordinary movement between quiet zones takes minutes and does not cost one watch per door.

One **work watch** permits each PC one substantial action toward Isolation, Evacuation, a research question or a declared similarly significant task. Helping uses that PC's contribution; ordinary inspections/conversations and movement may accompany it. This is expedition pacing, not a new pool of combat turns. Once/scene features do not refresh each watch while the same emergency objective remains active. If combat starts, pause work-watch advancement during that brief fight; Drift resumes on the next work watch unless a specifically warned physical event advances it.

## People with their own purposes

**Captain Ora Kel:** Oruun, unmodified, Ancients Kinship. Protect residents and preserve their home if possible. She accepts a plan that destroys the beacon, and does not demand a theological answer. She can pilot one habitat tender or assist a tow once its feed is isolated. Her leadership isn't an extra combat turn.

**Beren Taal:** gene-crafted human engineer, Order Dissenter. Wants the accident contained and the measurements preserved. Beren will explain their mistake if shown an actual safe plan. Offers tools and correct access codes without requiring social defeat; initially reluctant to destroy the beacon. A credible argument about the residents' risk wins cooperation. Beren cannot reverse the whole accident with a free NPC action.

**Jema Oss:** Oruun negotiator, Mechanical Continuant, Divinity Lantern. Wants a receiving berth with power, repairs and no compulsory body conversion. A port official's request for compatible charging/medical information is ordinary logistics; a demand for personal ownership records is a political refusal the crew can challenge. She can organize passengers once a route is agreed.

**Miri, Sabel and Kes:** an Oruun child who sketches routes, a mechanical human grandfather who tends a communal garden, and a Nacrean cook keeping the shelter fed. Each knows one useful practical fact: where a handcart is stored, which shutter latch sticks, and which tender's water loop needs a replaceable filter. They have lives beyond being endangered. Ask the crew whom they speak with; do not require a separate persuasion roll to receive each fact.

**Research liaison Ven Rook:** Veyran, secular, present by radio. Wants the experiment and safety file returned intact. Offers extra **1 Supply** for the hardware, but cannot order Ora around. Ven can give the receiving laboratory's address. Whether Ven helps expose the incorrect heat budget depends on evidence and an assurance it won't be falsified. This is one person's decision, not a species trait.

# Keyed opportunities

### 1. Shelter Hall: agree on a reachable outcome

Ora presents three viable plans. State their material requirements before the players choose.

- **Tow the home:** complete Isolation, attach the offered tow rig and move the habitat to the safe side. Residents remain aboard. One safe work watch completes the tow with the protagonists' ship and Ora's tender; no extra success roll after the prerequisites are met.
- **Evacuate:** complete Evacuation, launch the two working habitat tenders and guide them toward the announced receiving port. They have fuel for the route and their own ordinary pilots. The protagonists escort; no magical ninety-six-person capacity appears in a Courier.
- **Detach the experiment:** complete Isolation, move its anchored pod into empty Cargo Spine using the installed rail and abandon it with a locator. Then the habitat's auxiliary drive can make the safe move itself in one work watch. The experiment becomes a future salvage/research question.

Isolation and Evacuation are alternatives, though a cautious crew can progress both. Completing one doesn't erase the other's progress. If the crew invents a fourth plan, assess real tools, capacity and time using the same constraints.

**Evacuation work:** useful actions include Force to clear a jammed tender rail, Insight to replace Kes's known filter, Presence to organize boarding with a concrete inclusive plan, or Finesse to carry a guide line across a low-gravity gap. Relevant expertise may apply. Partial gives one progress or two and 1 Strain; failure blocks the chosen tender until someone spends one action with a new approach or 1 Supply for a spare. The other tender and alternative plan remain accessible. One successful ordinary message to the receiving port obtains emergency berths; it needn't consume Evacuation progress.

### 2. Cargo Spine: the confused guardian

A damaged **Deflector Frame** guards the Experiment Bay threshold. It has Guard 7, armor 1, damage 2 ranged and the chapter-11 reaction. It broadcasts a real warning: crossing without maintenance authorization triggers a shot on its activation. It does not attack while the crew stays outside its marked lane.

Beren's correct maintenance code, the labeled local service disconnect, or a four-progress technical task can disable its hostile routine. The disconnect is reachable from Auxiliary Engine through the alternate route. A Mechanical Continuant is a person, not an acceptable target for a shutdown code; this frame is a non-sentient machine explicitly built for remote service.

For four experienced PCs add **one Signal Hunter** at Engine if they knowingly activate an obsolete security mode. Announce this on the control before use. It seeks the beacon's transmitter and can be redirected to an ordinary signal decoy. Do not quietly add it because the crew's first plan worked. For two PCs use only the Frame; duet uses one Repair Automaton from chapter 4 instead. This is advisory scaling, not proven challenge calibration.

If a fight occurs, the residents remain behind Shelter's bulkhead and follow evacuation instructions. A missed shot does not randomly kill a named civilian. A crew can withdraw through the alternate route; the Frame doesn't pursue beyond Cargo Spine/Bay.

### 3. Experiment Bay: isolate the feed

The beacon sits in its rail-mounted pod. The physical steps are written on the panel: place a bypass, cool the contactor, release the locked feed. Use the shared Isolation task rather than three additional hidden clocks. Force with insulated tools can open the stuck coupling; Insight/Machinery can place a bypass; careful Finesse can work the rail latch. Presence can coordinate Beren and a willing repair team when they are genuinely available. The task needs a plausible approach, not a particular Vocation.

Partial: one progress safely or two and spend 1 Supply on a replacement fuse. Failure: mark one console as arcing. Before it is used again, a visible local disconnect must be thrown with an ordinary action from the other side of the bay; the unused console remains workable. Touching a known live arc without protection calls for one defense against damage 2. Once disconnected it stops. Repeated misses don't create an infinite room-wide damage aura.

A Mechanist's Overclock Sequence or Linked Systems can add their stated task progress. Their costs and limits still apply. A Biotic adaptation may protect a worker against studied coolant fumes but not electricity or radiation. A Psion may move a hand-sized fuse through a clear route, but cannot shift the whole pod with the novice feature. These are examples of useful scope, not exclusive solutions.

The three evidence sources are accessible while working. Reading the visible heat-budget discrepancy needs no separate roll once compared with the matching gauge. Copying it takes an ordinary interaction. Beren asks that the file include their actual decisions as well as the Covenant's error.

### 4. Shutter Gallery: preserve the margin

Inspecting the known sticky latch reveals it is partly blocked by a collapsed rack. A four-progress Force/Finesse/Insight task with actual leverage/tools clears it. Partial one progress or two +1 Strain; failure costs time spent on that action, but no additional Drift step. Completion maintains the promised shelter watch after Drift 6. Without it, the Gallery closes automatically and its route is lost, but Shelter Hall still provides that shelter watch through its independent shutters. The task preserves a convenient route and the outer garden; it isn't a secret prerequisite to survival.

A master Psion can shift the unattended human-sized rack with their listed feature if in range and the route is clear. That solves this obstruction, not the whole habitat emergency. A religious observance with willing residents can restore resources under its own rules and offer a human moment; it doesn't move Drift backward.

### 5. Auxiliary Engine: move or let go

Once Isolation is complete, a readable engine test confirms that tow or auxiliary movement is safe. Outside interference is not assumed. If the crew secured a safe tow or detached the pod, use the stated one-watch move. If they have completed Evacuation, both tenders can launch and clear the boundary within the same remaining work watch; the crew ship can escort on its next leg. When a successful move clears the lane, resolve that before an end-of-watch Drift step: the rescued habitat is no longer drifting toward the hazard.

If Drift reaches 6 before a plan is ready, shutters close and the single remaining shelter watch begins. Each PC still gets one work-watch contribution. At that watch's end, launch whatever tenders are ready, signal the supplied rescue tender and abandon the habitat if necessary. If even one tender remains jammed, Ora uses the emergency collar route to the rescue tender at the cost of leaving the home behind and accepting an emergency diversion. The rescue succeeds at greater material loss; it isn't free restoration of the habitat.

The Guide establishes this final fallback when the warning sounds. No new roll is needed merely to discover a rescue craft the scenario already promised. A group that knowingly refuses all evacuation after the warning can face a severe agreed consequence; the ordinary failure path is rescue with loss, debt and another job.

## Aftermath

Pay the main **3 Supply and 2 Stores** when residents reach safety or their habitat has been moved clear. Excess Supply can fund Stores/repairs before the cap. The fleet contact provides a reachable workshop and one ordinary free repair watch once; later repairs use normal costs. If the beacon survives and the crew accepts Ven's offer, pay the extra 1 Supply at the receiving laboratory, not immediately from nowhere.

Saving Kindled Road raises Trust with its Hearth community by 1 under the normal once/adventure limit. Evacuating its residents without the home earns the same gratitude but creates a real housing/reconstruction thread. The safety evidence can support negotiations with the Furnace Covenant, a public report or a careful independent replication. None forces an automatic faction war.

Ask each PC what they preserved that mattered: a person, a garden, a piece of evidence, a machine, a practice or a promise. Award normal session milestones for actual events, not a separate mandatory reward for being religious. End with two leads: the laboratory that supplied the file and a community asking for help finding a permanent berth.

## Scaling and observation

For duet reduce Isolation to 4, Evacuation to 2 and use the normal companion. Drift stays 6; the guided approach remains available. Beren can contribute one Help per work watch when physically assisting the PC, using that watch's meaningful NPC assistance rather than adding unlimited actions. The companion has its normal one contribution. For two PCs use Isolation 4 and Evacuation 4. For three/four use the written 6 and 4.

Record how many watches/actions each route used, which advanced features mattered, whether the crew had a visible fallback, and whether station tasks left someone idle. Do not label a character weak merely because their most specialized power did not fit one obstruction. If all players choose the same action each watch, note whether the objective was too homogeneous before adding numerical difficulty.

# Side adventure / The Unclaimed Crossing

**Guide only · optional groundside adventure · 2-3 hours · rank 1 · 2-4 PCs · provisional setting addition**

The last working crossing in an unnamed frontier district carries medicine, families and messengers. Three local coalitions want a say in its future. A damaged regulator is causing the bridge's foundations to fail. The party arrives with a medicine consignment before the next caravan. The central question is who will keep the crossing useful-and what they will demand in return.

No named god, approved faction history or canonical protagonist is introduced by this scenario. The local **Crossing Wardens** are civic guards, not the RTS Order Warden unit or a declaration of allegiance. All NPCs below are new.

## Prepare in five minutes

Draw five zones in a line: **Road -> Gate -> Span -> Pump House -> Far Bank**. Add a dangerous **Lower Walk** connecting Gate to Pump House; entering it while unstable requires a Finesse roll, partial cost 1 Strain, failure 1 damage and remain at Gate. Span has waist-high cover. Pump House has opaque walls; attacks cannot cross them. A PC in Span can see Gate and Pump House doorway. Other sight follows the line; no attack crosses more than one connection.

Draw **Collapse 0/6**, **Repair 0/6**, **Evacuation 0/4**. Collapse is an automatic danger clock, not a task clock. In tactical rounds advance Collapse by 1 at each round end unless someone that round spent an action bracing a support in Span or Pump House. Bracing is automatic, allows no other action, and cannot reduce Collapse. Outside rounds advance it once per major scene, announcing a visible warning first. Repair completion permanently stops Collapse. At Collapse 6 the central span fails: everyone there moves to Gate or Pump House at their choice and takes 2 damage; no unavoidable death. The Lower Walk remains available. Medicine still can be carried across by that route with a new safe-rigging task (4 clock).

Put two Rifle Guards at Gate, but **only one per two PCs rounded up** is active in any fight. Others escort civilians away and do not attack. The Gate clerk is unarmed. For duet use one guard, companion present, Repair 4, Evacuation 2; Collapse remains 6.

## People and conflicting goods

| Person / coalition | Genuine aim | Leverage | Will compromise if... |
|---|---|---|---|
| Mara Venn / Crossing Wardens | Keep the bridge working | Gate access and technical drawings | Someone supplies labor and accepts transparent inspections |
| Iven Sol / Open Hands | Deliver medicine without discriminatory tolls | Volunteers and a hidden 2-Supply cache | Delivery is guaranteed without forced religious pledge |
| Sela Marr / Witness Circle | Make repair and toll decisions public | Proof the regulator's maintenance was deferred | The records are opened and repairs are independently checked |

All have different sympathies toward the prototype Pantheons, but none is a canonical faction representative. A player's Pantheon contact may know one NPC; let the player choose that connection. All can be persuaded by concrete terms, not a single roll to erase principles.

## 1. Gate: the consignment

Read or paraphrase: “The bridge hums beneath the queue. A clerk holds your consignment slip beside a blank pledge form. Beyond the gate, a support cable jerks and showers the water with rust.”

Mara needs a declared recipient and escort to prevent theft. The clerk has interpreted this as requiring a pledge. The party can demand clarification, offer escorted delivery, sneak via Lower Walk, or force the gate. Show the disputed form without a roll. A credible bargain is automatic if it meets Mara's need. An unsupported bluff is Presence; partial costs an escort or a public obligation, failure brings Mara personally and advances Collapse by 1. Violent action starts tactical rounds; no faction automatically becomes irredeemably hostile.

At scene end reveal: the Pump House regulator has failed, civilians remain on Span, and a repair needs access to both records and machinery. Advance Collapse by 1 for the scene if no rounds occurred; do not also advance it for the same time spent in rounds.

## 2. Span: choose where to spend time

Three civilians are trapped behind fallen cargo. Moving them safely is the Evacuation clock: Force to clear, Finesse to rig a rope, Presence to coordinate. Ordinary clock outcomes apply; partial success can fill 1 without cost; failure advances Collapse by 1 as cargo shifts. Completing Evacuation gets them to Gate. Someone can instead hold the cargo as a bracing action. A Wayrunner's talent can carry one civilian across a safe connection, giving 1 Evacuation progress; at most one such progress per use, no additional roll.

Iven offers volunteers: accept a promise of impartial medicine delivery to gain 2 Evacuation progress once, or use them to brace for one round. This is a negotiated commitment, not a hidden trap. Refusal leaves other options open.

Delivering the medicine to Far Bank is an action once a carrier reaches it. It secures the immediate mission and gains 2 Supply at the adventure's end regardless of who controls the crossing. Until delivered the consignment is a carried objective; Downed carriers drop it in their zone. Picking it up is an action. Nobody can consume it for combat healing.

## 3. Pump House: evidence and repair

Sela has maintenance records showing repeated deferrals, not a secret villain confession. She shares them if the party agrees to a public inspection. Without her, PCs can obtain records from a locked office: Insight or Force, partial creates noise that draws Mara, failure takes time (+1 Collapse) but opens the office. The regulator's visible fault is discoverable automatically on inspection: a jammed governor and damaged brace. Records grant one edge on a repair roll, not a mandatory key.

Repair uses Insight with tools, Force to set braces, or a plausible rite plus practical work. Each successful action progresses Repair using the task clock. On a partial take 1 progress without cost, or 2 progress and spend 1 Supply. Failure advances Collapse by 1. Tools are available in the room. An Artificer's automatic device-disable talent can stop the regulator for safe handling, granting one edge to the next repair attempt; it does not finish the entire clock.

Mara will provide an Engine Tender if the party agrees to a neutral repair review; the tender spends its actions bracing instead of repairing or fighting. No extra enemy unit is added to compensate for negotiation.

## 4. Optional confrontation

If the party openly seizes the consignment, destroys records or threatens civilians, an independent salvage crew tries to take the unprotected regulator. Warn the players with footsteps and a shouted demand for surrender. Use **one Pursuer per two PCs rounded up**; for duet only one. They enter at Far Bank; do not combine this fight with surviving Gate guards. The crew wants portable parts, not martyrdom. Promise a later paid salvage contract or deny access and show united local resistance to end the encounter. A failed negotiation may start combat, but does not also give enemies a free turn.

For a harder four-PC replay, replace two regulars with one Creed Marshal, never add a leader on top. This is optional. Do not trigger a fight merely because players solved the preceding scenes peacefully.

## 5. The crossing covenant

Once people and medicine are safe or the bridge fails, let the party propose terms: a single custodian, a shared council, independence with public accounts, or withdrawal. Ask who pays upkeep, who can refuse a pledge, who inspects the regulator, and who receives medicine. NPCs accept terms that satisfy their stated needs; roll only for a contested remaining concession. No roll establishes universal belief or converts everyone.

If Repair completed, the crossing survives. If not, it becomes a ferry/Lower Walk reconstruction project. If Evacuation is unfinished at collapse, those civilians are stranded at Pump House, requiring a rescue scene; they are not automatically dead. Resolve their rescue before closing the adventure.

### Aftermath

For a roaming space-adventure campaign, delivered medicine pays 2 Supply, saving civilians and completing repairs earns +1 Trust at Crossing (once/adventure total), and the covenant becomes a relationship the crew can revisit. Offer a new port/job lead and move on. No territory upkeep applies. Ignore the Influence rewards below in this default mode.

**Optional territorial follow-through:** if the group wants to stay and organize, start a three-site campaign: **Crossing**, **Road Settlement**, **Far Bank Depot**. Each local coalition starts Influence 1 at Crossing, 0 elsewhere; party 0 everywhere. Grievance starts Crossing 1, other sites 0. Keep all faction Influence tracks separate.

- Medicine delivered: +2 Supply; the Depot accepts the party as trustworthy contacts.
- Evacuation completed or later rescue achieved: party Influence +1 at Crossing.
- Repair completed: party Influence +1 at Crossing, maximum 3.
- Civilian harm or broken public delivery promise: +1 Crossing Grievance per event, maximum 3.
- Public covenant: record two explicit commitments; no extra automatic Influence.

These are adventure results, not a free campaign project; the first campaign turn comes next and uses upkeep normally. Reveal rival projects before the party chooses its two projects: Wardens organize an inspection shift at Crossing; Open Hands stock a public dispensary at Depot; Witness Circle runs a public meeting at Road Settlement. Each would add 1 Influence only at its named site. Rivals each sustain up to two sites using their 2 upkeep tokens.

Award milestones using the core criteria. Ask each player what their Pantheon now demands and what their Creed failed to answer. End with an actionable next hook: the Depot's supplier wants the covenant extended to a second crossing, while one group fears that means expansion without consent.

# Playtest / Session record

Version / date / facilitator: _____

Mode: RPG / duet / skirmish. Player count and prior tabletop experience: _____

Pantheons, Aspects, Vocations and ranks: _____

Lineages / Embodiments / Disciplines (if rank 2+): _____

Scenario and duration: _____

Record actual observations separately from proposed fixes. No live sessions have been recorded in this repository yet.

| Observation | Record |
|---|---|
| Time until first meaningful Pantheon choice | |
| Rounds, attacks, misses and Downed characters | |
| Rites used / never useful / unclear | |
| Starting and ending Supply, Conviction and Accord | |
| Fractures and whether they felt voluntary | |
| Nonviolent approaches attempted / successful | |
| Each Vocation's meaningful contribution | |
| Influence gained/lost and upkeep paid | |
| Ship frame, Stores/Hull start and end; station actions per player | |
| Mission objective, discoveries, relics and new leads | |
| Human diversity shown without forced affiliation | |
| Religious activity used; was Zeal needed at all? | |
| Optional territory module used? (separate its results) | |
| Rules lookup that interrupted play | |
| A player choice the rules failed to support | |
| Skirmish first player, roster, scores and winner | |

After play ask each person: what felt distinctive; when did you lack a meaningful option; what would make you play again? Record disagreement. Change one major subsystem at a time and keep the previous version available in Git.

# Playtest / External session protocol

**Status: plan and fixtures, not completed sessions.** Automated software checks and scripted combat models do not count as external players. Use this protocol to gather evidence before passing the roadmap's live-play gates.

## What to bring

Two six-sided dice per player, paper/tokens, the Player's and Guide's Books, a ready sheet or exported companion roster, the relevant map and a blank playtest record. The companion is optional and offline; print works. Use the same manuscript revision within a test block, and record any temporary rulings.

For a first-learning check, give players only Start Here and their own ready sheet before play. Give the Guide the first-session preparation and scenario. Note where they need help from an author; that intervention is evidence, not something to hide. The rank-1 learning roster is separate from the rank-3 coverage block below.

## Six-session identity block

Each session is a real 2-3-hour meeting with a Guide and the stated PCs. Four group sessions plus two duets expose eighteen character builds. Each Pantheon appears with three Vocations and two Disciplines. This is planned coverage, not a statistically sufficient balance sample. Rotate players/roles where practical and record prior familiarity.

| Session | Builds | Scenario / main observation |
|---|---|---|
| A, four PCs | O1, A1, D1, O2 | Silent Berth: learning, rescue/social roles, ship basics |
| B, four PCs | A2, D2, O3, A3 | Glass Orchard: exploration, research, nonviolent alternatives |
| C, four PCs | D3, O4, A4, D4 | Quiet Glass: pressure, protection, Downed and evidence access |
| D, four PCs | O5, A5, D5, O6 | Sable Keel: positioning, carried cargo, technical/martial contributions |
| E, duet | A6 plus ordinary companion | Silent Berth duet: action economy, fallback access, ship stations |
| F, duet | D6 plus ordinary companion | Glass Orchard duet: survival, useful powers, route/clock pacing |

All six rosters start **rank 3**, full Guard 7, no wounds/Strain, Conviction 2, Supply 4, Accord 2, Courier Hull 8/Stores 4/Sanctuary berth. They are test builds, not a campaign that has magically advanced after one adventure. Use each scenario's rank-appropriate numbers and duet adjustments. The ordinary duet companion is the chapter-3 profile, **not** an extra divine PC hidden in the exported roster.

### Build key

| ID | Pantheon | Vocation | Discipline |
|---|---|---|---|
| O1 | Order | Bulwark | Mechanist |
| O2 | Order | Bulwark | Biotic |
| O3 | Order | Artificer | Mechanist |
| O4 | Order | Artificer | Biotic |
| O5 | Order | Witness | Mechanist |
| O6 | Order | Witness | Biotic |
| A1 | Ancients | Wayrunner | Psion |
| A2 | Ancients | Wayrunner | Freeblade |
| A3 | Ancients | Envoy | Psion |
| A4 | Ancients | Envoy | Freeblade |
| A5 | Ancients | Artificer | Psion |
| A6 | Ancients | Artificer | Freeblade |
| D1 | Divinity | Votary | Hierophant |
| D2 | Divinity | Votary | Psion |
| D3 | Divinity | Bulwark | Hierophant |
| D4 | Divinity | Bulwark | Psion |
| D5 | Divinity | Envoy | Hierophant |
| D6 | Divinity | Envoy | Psion |

The generator rotates Lineages, Embodiments, novice electives and Pantheon paths to expose diversity, not to optimize every character. A build being legal does not prove it equally effective. Give a player permission to explain an unfamiliar package before calling its turn uninteresting.

## Record during play

Use the session record. Capture initial/final resources, rounds, Downed characters, wounds, Fractures and objectives, plus the following observations:

- Time until the first meaningful Pantheon, Vocation, body or Discipline choice.
- At least one actual contribution-or lack of opportunity-from each PC's chosen packages.
- Which expertise claims were unclear, especially attacks/defense and ship handling.

- Which partial choices felt consequential and which were effectively free.
- Whether moving, Helping, taking cover, suppression or working an objective was chosen over damage.
- Whether close weapons felt useful when ordinary ranged weapons can also fire in their own zone; record positions and ability context before proposing a blanket penalty.
- Whether the crew could solve an adventure without a required faith, species or profession.
- Which religious scenes added discovery, community, wonder or conflict without needing Zeal.
- Where the Guide invented a missing rule or had to correct a reference.
- Whether rescue/retreat/failure paths remained reachable after a bad roll.
- Whether one player had little to do at ship stations or during investigation.

Write the observable event first ("two rounds waiting for a relevant target"), then a possible explanation ("the rite list may be too situational"). Don't erase a valid complaint because a theoretical combination could have helped.

## Short high-rank diagnostics

The rank-9 diagnostic roster has five specialists for **separate exercises**, not a balanced five-PC party. Reset each exercise's state explicitly; don't count the resets as in-fiction healing or progression. These checks can be appended to a group meeting, but record them as diagnostic phases rather than full adventures.

1. **Biotic:** one ally is stabilized at Guard 0/wounds 1; one is retired at wounds 3. Use Life Bridge and explain which target is eligible, its actual costs and next activation. Check full-day care separately.
2. **Mechanist:** a ship at Hull 0 cannot use ordinary field repair. At Hull 3/Engagement 0, test the adept foundation and a declared repair clock; distinguish Hull, System Damage and personal Guard.
3. **Psion:** compare a repeatable Kinetic Bolt with a rite and the once/session obstruction shift. Test Steady Mind or Far Grasp after a genuine pending Fracture; no interstellar mind-reading shortcut.
4. **Hierophant:** order an overreach, a partial-result substitution, a refund and a protective duration extension. Keep costs and trigger windows visible. Willing sharing is a choice, not a forced resource tax.
5. **Freeblade:** combine Measured Shot with a bulky/survey weapon, then test Last Stand at wounds 1 versus wounds 2. Three wounds still retires the character; no extra attack appears.

## Questions after play

Ask every person separately before discussing fixes: what made the character feel distinct; when did choices disappear; what was confusing; what was exciting; what would they change before another session? Ask the Guide what preparation was missing and which rule they quietly replaced.

Compare within similar situations, not raw wins across unrelated scenarios. Six sessions can reveal a recurring problem but cannot prove faction win-rate equality. After a consequential rule change, repeat the affected scene with clear inputs before treating an earlier result as current evidence.

## Provisional acceptance and next pass

A writing/learning pass is ready to broaden when new tables can finish the setup and a scenario without author-only knowledge, every package has understandable opportunities, no repeatable resource/action loop dominates, and serious rules conflicts have fixes. Treat repeated lack of contribution or a required "correct" build as an issue even when the party wins.

The six-session block addresses a minimum coverage gate, not commercial certification. Campaign attrition, first-time learning, competitive skirmish, broad equipment balance and long-term rank progression need additional evidence. Keep the old revision and actual notes so improvements can be assessed honestly.

## Roster files

Run `node scripts/build_playtest_rosters.cjs` to create the companion-compatible JSONs in playtest rosters. Import one file, check its stated rank/conditions, and replace descriptive details with player choices if desired. The imported presets don't contact or message anyone.

# Worked expedition / A turning point

This is an authored rules walkthrough with chosen dice, not a transcript or live playtest. It exercises the revised action/religion/reward loop in The Broken Beacon. It demonstrates legal decisions and accounting, not proof that the players would enjoy them or that this is an optimal tactic.

## Situation and starting ledger

Three rank-2 core explorers have reached the Service Gallery after earlier work. The following is the ledger at this point, not their original departure state. Their rank-2 Discipline features remain available but are not needed for the trace.

| Explorer | Relevant rolls | Guard / Strain / Conviction | Preparation |
|---|---|---|---|
| Taren | Force +2, no expertise on strikes/defense | 7 / 0 / 2 | Light armor available, brief observance unused |
| Cal | Insight +2, Machinery +1 on repair | 7 / 2 / 3 | Two earlier hazards caused the recorded Strain; brief observance already used |
| Neri | Finesse +2; Insight +1 without Machinery | 7 / 0 / 3 | Brief observance already used; one relic slot free |

Crew: Supply 4, Stores 3, Accord 2. One Maintenance Spider blocks the worksite: Guard 4, armor 1, close clamp damage 1. The crew has learned its command cable is reachable in the Gallery. The Guide has stated the ash front is still within the safe work watch and will start the announced countdown only when that watch ends.

## A risk worth choosing

Taren wants to force an opening and chooses a **damage Push** before a close strike. Pay 1 activation Strain: Taren 0 -> 1. Dice 3 +4 +Force 2 =9. The hit deals base 2 +Push 1 =3; armor 1 leaves 2 damage. Spider Guard 4 -> 2. Taren chooses exposure instead of the strike's additional Strain. Push did not turn the 9 into a 10.

The Spider takes its one activation and clamps Taren. Exposure makes damage 1 +1 =2. Defense dice 2 +3 +Force 2 =7. Taren chooses half damage rounded up plus 1 Strain: damage 1, Strain 1 -> 2. Light armor reduces that damage to 0 and is now spent. Exposure is consumed by the successful hit. No second counterattack occurs.

Neri activates, moves within the Gallery and uses her action to disconnect the exposed command cable. The Spider idles by its listed counterplay, despite still having Guard 2. It is not destroyed. This route was available instead of fighting; Taren's opening was a player choice, not a compulsory damage tax. Cal can use his remaining activation for the expedition's work. No new scene begins merely because the crew moves toward Refuge.

## A practice with a visible cost

At Refuge the Guide offers an additional, optional situation: a loose spare radio can be sold for 2 Supply, but it is the workers' only backup emergency set. Taren chooses to leave it, explains his commitment to keeping people safe, and the crew agrees to forgo that actual salvage opportunity. He regains 1 Conviction: 2 -> 3, marking the scene's shared Creed/practice claim. This is Order expressed through a concrete choice, not an imposed conversion or an extra prayer roll.

The same scene's ordinary Push payment did **not** earn the recharge. A different character could interpret their Creed differently or take the radio; the fictional relationship would change accordingly. Repeating the declaration cannot restore another point.

## The discovery changes the route

The workers reveal the **Promise Engine**, already pictured on the Lift's diagram. Neri spends ten peaceful minutes studying it within the remaining safe watch, readies it in her free relic slot, and chooses to use it now. One minute and 1 Conviction: Neri 3 -> 2. The intact Lift runs for a watch without its dead feed. Mark the Engine's one physical use this expedition. Passing it to Cal would not recharge it.

That opens a genuine route for the workers and crew. It does not also calibrate Beacon or complete an unrelated task clock. A future expedition might use the same device on a water pump or treatment light. Its recorded maintenance promise names a person the crew can seek later; the reward creates another relationship as well as an ability.

## Push meets Fracture

At Beacon, Calibration starts 0/6. Cal is still at Strain 2 from the starting ledger. He chooses a **progress Push**, reaching Strain 3 before rolling. Dice 2 +2 +Insight 2 +Machinery 1 =7. The reduced-effect partial fills 1 +Push 1 =2 progress. There is no additional cost for choosing this reduced-effect task result. Calibration 0 -> 2; Cal remains Strain 3.

Cal's next action is another Push. Pay the activation point: Strain reaches 4, so resolve Fracture **before** rolling. He can withdraw and lose the unresolved action with costs spent, or lose 2 Guard and continue. He chooses Guard: 7 -> 5, Strain resets to 1. Dice 3 +4 +2 +1 =10. Full task progress 2 +Push 1 =3; Calibration 2 -> 5. The rule has offered a real choice between capacity, safety and time, not a free bonus.

Neri takes an ordinary calibration action with a useful reachable control, using Insight +1 and no technical expertise. Dice 2 +4 +1 =7: reduced-effect progress 1, Calibration 5 -> 6. She has not needed to become an Artificer to contribute. The dangerous work ends before the ash closure; if it had begun, its announced round-end trigger would advance only once, not again for the same partial.

## Return with more than an invoice

Before Recovery: Taren Guard 7/Strain 2/Conviction 3; Cal 5/1/3; Neri 7/0/2. Supply remains 4, Stores 3, Accord 2. Calibration and the safe route fulfill the contract: receive 3 Supply, now 7. The workers entrust the Engine to the crew and the public repair record changes its relationship with the Harbor Compact. The Engine remains spent for this expedition.

If the crew takes its once/scene group Recovery after danger, pay 1 Supply: 7 -> 6. Everyone is at Guard 7 and Strain 0 afterward; Conviction stays 3, 3 and 2 respectively. Recovery does not recharge the Engine, Neri's brief observance or Taren's already-used scene claim. The crew leaves with payment, a wonder and a changed relationship. No milestone is awarded merely for pressing the Push button; award normal milestones for the resolved expedition and genuine personal choices.

## What still needs human play

Does preparing Push slow a turn or make its stakes clearer? Does the extra effect compete with too many class abilities? Is the one-point cost enticing enough at low Strain and dangerous enough near 4? Do players actually use observance to express a character, or treat it as a checkbox? Does the wonder inspire another use without displacing everyone else's tools? Record those observations from live tables rather than inferring them from this selected-dice trace.

# Campaign / Open Routes framework

**For the Guide · ten-episode framework, not ten fully keyed adventures.** Six episodes below link to complete scenarios; the remaining four are structured follow-ups with preparation prompts. Use, reorder or replace them according to the crew's choices. Most groups beginning at rank 1 reach roughly ranks 5-8 over ten sessions depending on actual milestones and downtime; rank 10 isn't promised by an episode number.

## The campaign question

Who gets to decide what the Reach becomes when new routes, technologies and sacred discoveries appear? The crew begins with a working ship and local jobs. Rescue contacts, scientific discoveries, religious ties, human bodily diversity and alien communities gradually give them influence. The central conflict concerns material choices and people, not filling a universal Zeal bar.

## Three recurring forces

### The Open Passage Fellowship

The Fellowship's ships carry pilgrims, passengers, medical teams and rescue crews. Some captains are devout; others operate secular mutual-aid charters. Its public purpose is useful passage rather than conversion. Small crews argue about risk, fees, scarce berths and whether they should accept a patron's money.

**Face: Captain Rhea Moss**, unmodified human, Ancients Wanderer, a practical navigator with a terrible singing voice. She wants the crew to become reliable independent partners rather than obedient employees. **Resource:** routes, contacts and ordinary shelter. **Pressure:** she has promised more rescue capacity than the Fellowship currently has. **Adventure use:** a call for help, a borrowed module, an uncomfortable choice between two worthwhile destinations.

### The Gilded Maw

A loose pirate market built around stolen power cells, salvage laundering and intimidation. Crews include several species, body forms and beliefs; the common bond is profit and mutual protection, not a single god or biology. Individual captains can bargain, defect or remain straightforward antagonists.

**Face: Daska Venn** of Sable Keel. **Resource:** fast ships, informants, stolen cargo. **Pressure:** buyers are asking for riskier acquisitions and paying in restrictive obligations. **Adventure use:** boarding, pursuit, an uneasy temporary alliance, a stolen artifact auction, recovery of a friend's ship. Daska knows when her choices hurt civilians; sympathetic history doesn't erase that responsibility.

### The Furnace Covenant

A research-industrial coalition attempting to build a portable stellar power network from recovered Dawncores and old harvesting rigs. It includes Order engineers, Divinity transcendence schools, Ancients navigators, secular sponsors, biological and mechanical humans, and nonhuman collaborators. It is a political/research alliance, not a fourth compulsory Pantheon.

**Face: Archbuilder Iria Sorn**, gene-crafted human Artificer/Hierophant associated with Divinity's Lantern tradition. She believes a new power network can reopen dangerous routes and protect isolated habitats. Her command circle has begun treating inhabited communities as acceptable sources of equipment and involuntary test data. Some members oppose that policy; others profit from it or sincerely accept the sacrifice.

**Resource:** laboratories, hired vessels, technical expertise and propaganda. **Pressure:** the demonstration deadline precedes completion of its safety network. **Adventure use:** a tempting contract, rescue from a failed test, sabotage of a weaponized collector, or a genuine alternative plan that makes coercive extraction unnecessary. Iria can be an antagonist without making religion, gene-craft or ambition inherently evil.

## Stakes that change visibly

Track three campaign questions as **open / pressured / resolved**, not a mandatory currency:

- **Passage:** can ordinary people safely use the routes the crew uncovers?
- **Power:** are habitats secure, dependent or losing essential equipment?
- **Trust:** which communities and individuals still believe the crew's promises?

After a significant adventure, update only questions affected by actual events. Give an observable sign: a new berth opens, an emergency broadcast requests parts, a festival host introduces a refugee family, a pirate captain changes terms. There is no automatic faction spread or offscreen catastrophe every time the crew takes a rest.

## Ten possible episodes

| Episode | Situation | Status / purpose |
|---|---|---|
| 1. A ship and a call | The Silent Berth | Fully keyed. Rescue/investigation; contacts and the first recording |
| 2. The world below | The Glass Orchard | Fully keyed. Survey, artifact and several ways to handle extraction |
| 3. The return signal | Quiet Glass | Fully keyed. Close the opening mystery and choose a wider route |
| 4. A stolen sunrise | Raid on the Sable Keel | Fully keyed. Boarding, prisoners, cargo and an emerging buyer |
| 5. A place to belong | Festival of Nine Lights | Fully keyed interlude. Religion, celebration and personal ties |
| 6. Serev's fault | A transit hall transmits a rescue pulse through a disputed sensor system | Structured seed below. Alien civic/physical exploration |
| 7. A Hearth adrift | A Hearth Adrift | Fully keyed. Higher-rank rescue, containment and ship decisions |
| 8. Beneath Pelara | Receding water exposes an old power interchange near a lived-in neighborhood | Structured seed below. Underwater exploration and archaeology |
| 9. The collector | A Covenant rig drains a habitat through the Sun-Eater installation | Runnable encounter in chapter 11 plus preparation below |
| 10. The route you choose | Resolve the demonstration, debts and selected personal quests | Finale framework below, requiring Guide preparation |

Each episode can span more than one meeting or be replaced by a personal quest. Use real travel costs and reachable ports. The optional Unclaimed Crossing can fit on an inhabited world whenever a crew wants a groundside detour.

# Preparing episodes 6-10

### Serev's fault

Map five zones: Public Hall, Sealed Transit, Sensor Gallery, Maintenance Shaft and Foundation Refuge. Connect Hall to Transit/Gallery, Gallery to Shaft, Shaft to Transit/Refuge, and Transit to Refuge. A physical tremor threatens Refuge; three workers and an old maintenance drone are inside. Prepare a Rescue 4-clock and Structural Failure countdown 6, advancing per work watch or warned combat round, not both. Structural failure seals Transit but leaves Shaft reachable with a repair task.

Council engineer Sesh Am wants an emergency sensor connection; courier Rin wants a limited agreement preserving private routes; archivist Tel Varo wants verifiable results. Give the crew a physical fault trace, a disputed sensor record and a human witness who lives here. Use two Repair Automata only if their safety lock creates a genuine obstacle; a valid maintenance order or shutdown can avoid combat. Reward 4 Supply and an archive introduction. The unresolved question is what access survives after the emergency, not whether Veyrans all think alike.

### A Hearth adrift

Use the complete scenario: six keyed zones, a guided or risky ship approach, Isolation and Evacuation alternatives, a visible Drift clock starting 2/6 on arrival, concrete evidence and a material-loss fallback. Captain Ora Kel, Beren Taal and Jema Oss connect the rescue to fleet life and the Covenant's research. Preserve its clock timing when adapting it; don't also advance Drift for the same brief combat or corridor movement. The lost home or preserved beacon can shape episode 8's needs without forcing the crew into a predetermined political allegiance.

### Beneath Pelara

Map Landing Pier, Dive Lock, Floodworks, Old Interchange, Archive Niche and Current Channel. Pier connects Lock; Lock connects Floodworks/Channel; Channel connects Interchange; Floodworks connects Interchange/Niche. Both routes are usable with pressure-rated equipment provided by a reachable supplier. Amphibious breathing doesn't confer deep-pressure immunity, but it helps in shallow zones.

Prepare Survey 6 and Current Shift countdown 6, advancing per expedition watch. At 6 the direct route floods; Current Channel remains a longer exit. Give three physical discoveries: mismatched repair methods, a calendar aligned to tides, and a relay label matching Covenant cargo. Two Terrace Grazers translated to appropriate local fauna guard nesting places; they can be avoided through timing and alternate routes. Nema, Kes Il and Anri from the society dossier have useful competing needs. Pay 4 Supply for verified findings; a preserved relay can become a relic research project, not a free weapon of limitless scale.

### The collector

Use the Sun-Eater Engine's full zone map, two components, shutdown alternatives and Feedback consequence in chapter 11. It is now being activated as part of a Covenant demonstration, so one named researcher and one contract guard stand nearby; they are people with goals, not automatic extra attack turns on top of the whole installation. The researcher can reveal a maintenance window, and the guard can permit evacuation while still opposing sabotage.

Add one meaningful moving objective: an engineer stranded at Relay Walk, a rescue tender's trapped clamp, or a data core needed for safe shutdown elsewhere. Choose it before play. The habitat's loss state is backup power and an evacuation deadline, not the immediate death of every resident. A successful crew gets the proof and leverage needed for the finale, plus repair/refuel support, instead of an arbitrary larger pile of damage bonuses.

### The route you choose

Offer the crew at least three credible end plans: stop the demonstration and return stolen cores; replace extraction with a distributed voluntary network using their discoveries; or evacuate threatened communities while exposing the project and leaving its future unresolved. Prepare Iria's actual commitments and what evidence could change her policy. Some command-circle members may defect; others continue as active opponents. Do not make every apparent option secretly lead to the same forced duel.

Use three fronts, each requiring a distinct contribution: a ship corridor for rescue/defense, a technical control for the demonstration, and a public agreement for what happens afterward. Run **one tactical scene at a time** with observable consequences linking them; don't demand that each player operate a separate game simultaneously. A 6-clock solution at the control, one cutter/group pursuit and a concrete negotiated proposal can resolve the climax without a new rules subsystem. If the crew chooses a fight, use an elite plus limited support and a visible objective rather than a god with surprise immunity.

End by revisiting one personal quest per PC, the ship's future and the actual communities affected. The crew can become explorers, leaders, teachers, pilgrims, rivals or simply friends with another route to try. Success never requires converting the whole sector or endorsing a single account of the gods.

## Make the framework yours

Use these locations and factions as working continuity for this tabletop game. The inspiration ledger records the connection to Manifest Destiny / ROZ; these new events don't rewrite those source stories. If a table wants a more mythic, martial, scientific or eerie campaign, change which unanswered questions receive attention while preserving visible stakes and player choices.